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'NO VOY A HACER OTRA COSA PARA QUE A TI TE GUSTE'

EL MUNDO DE BAD BUNNY

por ***ANDREW R. CHOW & MARIAH ESPADA***

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Bad Bunny’s Next Move

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In 40 minutes, the former grocery bagger from Puerto Rico will try on outfits worth thousands for the cover of this magazine. In 12 hours, he will be photographed embracing the world’s highest-paid supermodel. In one month, he will be staring out onto a sea of 125,000 superfans from the heights of Coachella’s main stage.

But right now, Benito Antonio Martínez Ocasio, who also goes by Bad Bunny, is slouched almost completely horizontally on a green-room couch in downtown Los Angeles, thinking about being with his parents back home in Puerto Rico.

“Outside of that house, perhaps the world is listening and talking about me,” he murmurs in Spanish. “But in that house, everything is the same. Nothing has changed. It’s beautiful for me to go there

and they still look at me with the eyes of, ‘Come here, Benito Antonio. The baby. The son.’”

Bad Bunny wants to be the biggest artist in the world—and he is. Last year, his fifth solo studio album, *Un Verano Sin Ti*, was Billboard’s top-performing album of the year, beating out Taylor Swift and Harry Styles. He broke the all-time record for tour revenue in a calendar year—with $435 million earned—and was Spotify’s most streamed artist for the third year in a row. But Bad Bunny also wants to just be Benito; to do whatever he wants, or *hace lo que le da la gana*, as he named his sophomore album. And until this point, it is exactly this mentality that has brought him unprecedented success. Where other musicians reaching for his

level of stardom have hidden certain parts of themselves, Benito has refused to compromise: on the language he sings in; the political stances he assumes; the dresses and nail polish he wears.

Read More: *'Hago Música Como Si Fuera la Única Persona en el Mundo.' Bad Bunny sobre Coachella, Hollywood y Superándose a sí Mismo*

Bad Bunny is perhaps the world's first reverse crossover artist, whose success comes from a refusal to cater to the mainstream. His stubborn originality, independence, and fiercely local lens have made him a radically new kind of global pop star, etching pathways to success that completely bypass New York or Hollywood industry gatekeepers.

But the further Benito ascends into the stratosphere, the more the expectations of his growing fandom threaten to exceed what his whims can deliver. His unequaled stature means he is often asked to speak for an entire region, a responsibility that he alternately embraces and chafes at. During the course of our conversation, he dances around political questions and refers to himself as a *chamaquito*—a little boy.

Seven years into his career, Benito, 29, is a legitimate heir to Frank Sinatra, Michael Jackson, or Beyoncé. How he navigates this next fraught period could determine how close he can come to meeting the near impossible expectations placed on him by his fans, his homeland, an exacting industry—and himself.

“I always say that if a thousand people listened to me and I performed once a month at a little place, just with that I would be happy,” he says in his deep baritone and distinctly Puerto Rican inflection. “But the hunger and the passion that I have for this is impossible, because I always want to give more and more and more.”

In 2022, Bad Bunny had the type of pantheon year that even other pop superstars dream about. *Un Verano Sin Ti* topped the *Billboard* charts for 13 non-consecutive weeks, with the least played song on the record racking up 190 million Spotify streams. In November, *Un Verano Sin Ti* became the first entirely Spanish-language album to receive a Grammy nomination for Album of the Year.

Read More: *'I Make Music Like I'm the Only Person in the World.' Bad Bunny on Coachella, Hollywood, and Topping Himself*

Benito's success starts with his inimitable singing voice, which is malleable enough to be imbued either with cutthroat swagger or pathos. He's a master aural chemist, melding together decades of Latin music into cutting-edge mixes that resonate at the club, on the beach, or at home on a lazy Sunday afternoon. And he creates at a startlingly fast pace. "I'll send him an idea and tomorrow night, there are vocals in an email that don't need any adjustments," the producer Tainy, who is one of his main collaborators, tells TIME.

Benito has achieved all of this without releasing a single song in English, or making any real attempt to cross over. Other Latin artists have scored megahits in Spanish: Ritchie Valens' "La Bamba" back in 1958, Los Del Río's 1993 hit "Macarena," Luis Fonsi's "Despacito" in 2017. But U.S. interest has ebbed and

flowed, with subgenres like Latin pop and reggaeton—a genre that blends Jamaican and Latin musical influences with hip-hop elements—dismissed by industry insiders as fads.

Bad Bunny grew up in the midst of reggaeton's first mainstream moment. San Juan, P.R., and artists like Daddy Yankee and Ivy Queen played crucial roles in the genre's evolution in the '90s and '00s. As a teenager, Benito listened to reggaeton and other forms of Latin music, and anointed himself Bad Bunny based on a childhood photo taken of him in a bunny costume. He started recording in his room and uploading songs to Soundcloud, and his first hit, "Diles," blew up when he was 21. Five critically acclaimed and commercially successful solo albums followed, along with a Super Bowl performance with Shakira and 10 music videos that have each surpassed a billion views on YouTube.

Read More: *Allow Bad Bunny to Teach You Puerto Rican Slang*

You don't accomplish all this without being relentlessly motivated. When asked whether he cares about maintaining his position at the top, he says, "I always say no, but I think I lie. Because if there is someone who made a *cabrona* song, I am going to make a more *cabrona* song." The word *cabrón*, which is a stronger vulgarity in some cases, often signifies "badass" in Puerto Rican slang.

All this has unfolded against the streaming boom, which has given fans direct access to regional music. Executives are now focused on sheer streaming numbers as opposed to radio spins, and Latin music is growing faster than any other genre in the U.S. No one is streamed more than Bad Bunny. He has proved to the industry that hits don't need to be manufactured by Max Martin's assembly line: that they can be freestyled on an island 3,000 miles away from Los Angeles.

While accepting a Grammy onstage in February, Benito dedicated his trophy to Puerto Rico, where his journey began. He grew up the oldest of three brothers in Almirante Sur, a rural area in Vega Baja, a 45-minute drive from San Juan. His parents, a truck driver and a teacher, went through both easy and “difficult times to bring us food,” he says. All the while, they filled their Catholic household with salsa and merengue music from stars like Héctor Lavoe and Elvis Crespo.

Benito’s rise has paralleled a particularly tumultuous period in Puerto Rican history. In 2016, the same year he released his first single, Congress enacted the Puerto Rico Oversight, Management, and Economic Stability Act (PROMESA) in an effort to restructure the island’s estimated $70 billion in debt. The federal law resulted in austerity measures that have cut back on public services for the island, which has one of the highest poverty rates in the U.S. Puerto Rico was under Spanish colonial rule for 400 years before transitioning into a fraught, century-long commonwealth relationship with the U.S., which has been marked by such indignities as coerced sterilization. Debates surrounding statehood have been in limbo since the population first voted on a status referendum over 50 years ago.

During Hurricane Maria in 2017, one of the deadliest natural disasters and the largest blackout in U.S. history, Benito's parents lost power for months. In 2018, after President Trump visited the island and threw paper towels into a crowd, Benito declared on *The Tonight Show* that "more than 3,000 people died and Trump is still in denial." In 2019, he put his tour on hold to join protests in San Juan calling for the removal of Governor Ricardo Rosselló.

Read More: *How Puerto Ricans Are Fighting Back Against the Outsiders Using the Island as a Tax Haven*

Benito is increasingly careful with his words on politics, conscious that being the biggest Puerto Rican star in the world comes with the ability to shift public discourse. Whereas a 2019 Instagram post encouraging Puerto Ricans to join him in protest was direct, his comments today are more equivocal. “I think the [U.S.] government has failed Puerto Rico,” he says, before backtracking slightly. “It’s failed the United States. Equally, Puerto Rico has failed Puerto Rico. I believe that all governments have failed their country at some point.”

His music is less inhibited. His 2022 song “El Apagón” rails against Puerto Rico’s current Governor Pedro Pierluisi and the constant power outages since its electrical grid was privatized. Instead of a traditional music video, Benito released a short documentary alongside independent journalist Bianca Graulau about the displacement that has resulted from Act 60, a law that offers tax incentives to foreigners.

Benito makes music that reflects the multi-faceted experience of life itself, moving within a few verses from lyrics about sex to Puerto Rico’s lack of infrastructure. He isn’t interested in making reggaeton that’s only *perreo* (dance-party tracks), nor is he trying to make politically correct records for an older, more conservative, and vulgarity-averse Latino demographic.

Read More: *Bad Bunny Speaks Out on Black Lives Matter Protests*

His songs and acts of political resistance are widely celebrated—and are now even the subject of at least one college class. But his ascendence has not come without criticism. In 2020, many on social media called out him and other *urbano* artists for failing to engage in conversations about anti-Blackness following the murder of George Floyd, especially given reggaeton’s history of rewarding white-presenting artists while neglecting its Black roots. Benito is

white-presenting, but is often referred to as *jabao*, a Puerto Rican of mixed race.

When Benito is asked whether he believes race and colorism play a role in the success of a reggaeton artist, he responds, “Because I haven’t seen it or lived it, I can’t say. It’d be irresponsible of me to say yes. They asked me about if [’00s reggaeton superstar] Tego Calderón would’ve been bigger if he wasn’t Black. But in my eyes, Tego Calderón is the biggest singer in the industry.”

Music historian Katelina “Gata” Eccleston of Reggaeton Con La Gata, who has long studied reggaeton and its racial elements, calls Benito a “great ambassador,” and believes that no one artist should be held accountable for the industry’s failures around colorism. Still, she says Benito’s comments above show that “he still does not understand his positionality.”

Benito is frustrated by how his political lyricism seems to necessitate his answering political questions on behalf of the millions of disparate residents of his home island. “That question could be a bit unfair because I simply do a song and then a responsibility so big falls on you,” he says. “You’re not going to ask Daddy Yankee something like that.”

Over the pandemic, Benito hunkered down in Puerto Rico. Now, he often finds himself in Los Angeles, which is where TIME meets him on a balmy March morning. He arrives in fashionable yet comfy clothes: baggy Balenciaga sweats and a yellow-trimmed Moncler puffer jacket covering a shirt of the Mexican pop icon Juan Gabriel. His accessories include Y2K-style sunglasses, a skull ring, mismatched heart earrings, blush-pink nails, and three layered gold chains.

Read More: *Reggaeton Is So Much More Than Party Music. This Podcast Breaks Down Its Political Roots*

Over the course of several hours, Benito speaks in hushed tones, at times raising his voice excitedly to punch home a point or jokingly insult a member of his posse sitting in the corner. Later on, he teases playing an unreleased song, reaching for his phone in jest.

Benito's attention to detail is apparent as he prepares for the photo shoot. Wearing a floor-length Willy Chavarria coat and a sizable white flower on his chest, he makes his way through piles of jewelry before adding a pearl necklace to his already well-adorned neck. "Beautiful. *Me gusta*," he says in Spanglish as he looks in a mirror.

Los Angeles' appeal to Benito includes Hollywood, which he is keen to immerse himself in. He recently appeared in *Narcos: Mexico* and *Bullet Train*, which featured him in a life-or-death brawl opposite Brad Pitt. David Leitch, *Bullet Train*'s director, says that Benito was fastidious about learning the fight choreography, asking to rehearse scenes over and over. "I'd love to do an action movie where he's the lead," Leitch says. "He has a soulfulness and an incredible empathetic quality."

Benito also appeared in biopic *Cassandro*, in which he plays a paramour to Gael García Bernal. "My first kiss for a movie and it

was with a man," he says, laughing. "That's the penalty I get for being with so many women during my life."

He took the job seriously. "If you're acting, you're being someone you're not," he says. "So when they asked me for that, I said, 'Yes, I'm here for whatever you want.' I think it was very cool; I didn't feel uncomfortable."

Read More: The Best Latin Songs and Albums of 2022

Benito is part of a rising generation of male pop stars challenging stereotypical masculine ideals. He has kissed a male dancer onstage, appeared in drag, and declared that his heterosexuality does not define him. He used a 2020 appearance on *The Tonight Show* to call attention to the murder of a transgender woman, Alexa Negrón Luciano, in Puerto Rico. This month, he will receive GLAAD's Vanguard Award for his LGBTQ allyship.

Last year, Sony Pictures announced he would star in a Spider-Man spin-off, *El Muerto*, as Marvel's first Latino superhero. At the time, Benito said that the role was "perfect" for him, as he grew up watching wrestling and called his 2021 WWE Wrestlemania debut "the best day of my life." But during our interview, Benito feigned confusion when asked about the movie and said that no filming had yet taken place. Benito's publicist said that the movie was "at a standstill," and later clarified that it's "in development." (A representative for Sony declined to comment on the record.)

"Maybe they'll switch me out for Pedro Pascal," Benito says jokingly.

Benito's Hollywood dreams are sometimes dampened when he encounters a lack of understanding about his homeland: "If I hear something very ignorant about my country or my culture, I always try to educate them, like 'No, it's not like that.'" At the Grammys in early February, his exuberant opening number was nearly overshadowed by the program's live captioning, which read "singing in non-English." "It was *porqueria* (crap)," Benito says dismissively.

He is currently preparing for his Coachella performances, which will take place on April 14 and 21 in Indio, Calif., and mark the first time a Latino artist has headlined the festival. Coachella has hosted massive stars, but the gig doesn't seem to faze him. "Am I supposed to feel something?" he asks incredulously. "I felt more pressure at the Hiram Bithorn [Stadium in Puerto Rico] than I feel for Coachella."

Read More: *Bad Bunny Is on the 2021 TIME 100*

The bigger he gets, the more invasive his fans have become. In January, he was filmed throwing a fan's phone in a nearby body of water after she started to film them together. "I always say I will never say no to someone who comes up to me to say hi. If you're coming up like you're going to rob me, then yes, it'll bother me," he says. "Why do you want a picture with me? Because I'm the Statue of Liberty? I'm a human. Greet me."

Several hours after the interview, Benito ignites another firestorm when paparazzi photograph him embracing supermodel Kendall Jenner, a member of the Kardashian dynasty. Many Latino social media users treated this potential romance as a fundamental betrayal. Benito has often sung about his love for Latin women and culture, even dismissing the non Latinos who want to participate in reggaeton culture or take advantage of Puerto Rican land as lacking *sazón* (flavor). "It ain't Benito no more, it's Ben," went a common refrain on social media.

Benito declined to comment on the dating rumors. But he says he feels less strongly about the *sazón* lyric than when he wrote it. “I was upset,” he says. “But now that feeling has passed me. Our culture and music impacts people in other places. They want to try it and feel it. So why am I going to be bothered by that, if they do it with respect?”

Benito says that the “only reception” for his music he cares about is from Puerto Rican fans. But he also says he remains unbothered by his critics. “When I read comments that say, ‘Bad Bunny now I’m not going to listen to your music,’ that’s fine,” he says. “I’m not going to do something else for you to like it. There are plenty of artists, and perhaps you’ll find someone you’ll like.”

As much as Benito purports to be carried downstream by his desires, he also acutely understands the fleeting nature of fame. “I release an album now and a week passes and 15 new albums have arrived,” he says. “So to maintain yourself right there in the position at the top is way more difficult than before.”

Read More: *The 10 Best Albums of 2022*

Bad Bunny doesn’t have to change anything: he’s already fulfilled the dreams of so many Puerto Ricans and flipped the music industry on its head. Musically, he will continue to do whatever he wants: while he decorated his studios with a tropical decor for *Un Verano Sin Ti*, he says that lately, his space embodies a ’70s vintage vibe. He has continued to record music this year, he says, but without a specific deadline.

Yet because he loves being on top, he is realizing that some compromise may be necessary in order to stay there. This includes learning more English. “There’s a lot of things that I’m losing, like opportunities, ’cause the language,” he says in English. “I didn’t care about [learning] English. But now, I think I care.” He adds that

any English-language song he writes will be on his own terms: “The day I feel like I need to do a song in English, I’ll do it because I feel it.”

The social media fallout of the Jenner photo reinforced how every one of his personal choices is scrutinized through a larger cultural lens. This is a heavy weight to bear for someone who, as much as he genuinely cares about his country, doesn’t feel like an island’s fate should fall on his shoulders alone.

“I am a *chamaquito*, and we have different preoccupations and desires to do one thing one day and the next not. One moment we go to the club to drink and smoke, and tomorrow I want to be

chilling at home watching a movie. And then next I'll be thinking about my ex or a girl that I like," he says, sitting slightly more upright than when the interview began. "And then tomorrow I am bothered over something I think is an injustice. But then by night I go to eat tacos, they give me a bit of tequila, and I've forgotten."

—*With reporting by Israel Meléndez Ayala*

Styling by Nycole Sariol; Hair by Tanya Melendez; Make-up by Bo; Production by Aries Rising Projects

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Biden Wants the Word ‘Again’ to Haunt Republicans Like it Does Him

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This article is part of The D.C. Brief, TIME’s politics newsletter. Sign up here to get stories like this sent to your inbox.

At moments like this, there is one word in Joe Biden’s vocabulary that he wishes he could purge: *again*.

It’s been a constant during his two-plus years as President and his eight as the understudy. Over that time, Biden has repeatedly had to shoehorn *again* into his preplanned remarks on another subject, to pepper it into hastily called statements from a White House podium or en route to another event.

“You know, the shooter in this situation reportedly had two assault weapons and a pistol—two AK-47,” Biden said Monday afternoon

in the White House's East Room, where he was forced to preface his speech to the Small Business Administration's summit for women with an update on the school shooting in Nashville that left six dead. "So, I call on Congress, *again*," he said, "to pass my assault weapons ban. It's about time that we begin to make some more progress."

Progress will be hard to find. Detour, much easier. And Biden knows it. *Again* isn't getting shoved in a junk drawer any time soon. School shootings, musical festival massacres, and grocery store slaughters alike have been unable to soften Americans' hardened sclerosis when it comes to gun rights.

Since taking office in early 2021, there have been more than 50,000 deaths by mass shootings, according to the Gun Violence Archive. Since January 1, 2021, there have been 1,468 mass shootings—or 1.8 of them each day.

Biden has repeatedly deployed *again* as a drumbeat in his remarks, a bit of venting and self-flagellation. "I am determined once again to ban assault weapons and high-capacity magazines," he said two weeks ago, when visiting a Boys and Girls Club site in Monterey Bay, Calif. Back in January, he was hammering the point, too: "We're going to ban assault weapons again. I did it once as a senator. We're going to do it again."

Biden was talking about the 1994 Crime Bill, which banned assault weapons for ten years. The votes weren't there in Congress to renew it in 2004, in large part because many Democrats blame their shellacking in the wake of the bill's passage—the House had a net 54-seat swing—on Republicans successfully fomenting outrage over the ban and other provisions in the landmark measure.

Even in the earliest days of his presidency, Biden was leaning on *again* to imply a frustration, an exhaustion, an anger that seldom boils over in public: "Let me say it again: Gun violence in this

country is an epidemic, and it's an international embarrassment," Biden said from the Rose Garden in April of 2021, just 78 days into his term. A month later, Biden was again at it, speaking to his first joint sessions of Congress: "We need a ban on assault weapons and high-capacity magazines again. Don't tell me it can't be done. We've done it before. And it worked."

Again. It's a simple word. Most people don't have much of a hangup on it. It's one of those throw-away words that pepper daily conversation without too much importance. But, for Biden and those around him, it's a reminder that despite an unflinching attention to the domestic challenge, he doesn't exactly have a lot to show for it. The D.C. Brief has written dozens of times about the uphill politics facing Biden and Democrats on gun control. Over the course of my career, I've probably written hundreds of pieces about the odds of meaningful changes to gun laws. And, time and time again—that word, again—the verdict is no more favorable to action.

True, the NRA is a shell of its former self, decimated by management and financial crises. Its political operation is a shadow of its once giant stature, yet it still commands fear in lawmakers, especially Republicans who know even the slightest deviation from all-guns-are-to-be-defended orthodoxy. In the wake of the Uvalde, Texas, shooting that left 19 students and two educators dead, Sen. Kevin Cramer of North Dakota was blunt when asked what voters would do if he considered any real check on guns: "Most would probably throw me out of office."

It's brutal, but true. Americans overwhelmingly support specific tightened controls on guns, with even the least popular restriction —a ban on assault-style weapons—still logging 63% support among all Americans, according to Pew. The same survey found 81% support for background checks and 87% supported limits in the name of mental health with all Americans.

But Americans are deeply divided, and the broad notion of “gun control” is a clunker. A staggering 45% of homes in America have at least one gun, so this is personal. In last year’s midterm elections, support for stricter gun laws found support among 56% of voters, according to exit polls; 76% of Democrats agreed, while 88% of Republicans did not. To think consensus is waiting in the wings is a foolish use of optimism, especially in a mightily divided Official Washington.

Republicans with and without weapons alike have used gun rights as a stand-in for freedom from government nosiness, and just 37% of them support a ban on assault-style weapons, according to Pew. Republicans are none-too-eager to give Biden any measure of a policy win heading into an expected 2024 re-election campaign. For Biden, who led the efforts to move both policy and public perception on guns during the Obama Administration, the stubborn attitudes have proved personally vexing. The fact that recent Gallup surveys have found support for laws making it tougher to buy guns moving in a direction opposite of Biden’s goals is particularly disturbing.

Safety isn’t inherently a political question, but its perception cannot be discounted. Exit polls last year found Republicans with a net nine-point advantage on the question of which party is to be trusted more on crime. Which is, in part, why Biden is putting so much of his emotional interest in confronting crime and its leading ingredient as he prepares for an announcement that he’s seeking a second term.

Yet *again* has never been far from the lexicon of Biden’s speechwriters or his own handwritten additions in the margins. For a politician who can sometimes be mistaken for an Irish poet, the fatalism is hard to miss. “I had hoped, when I became President, I would not have to do this again,” Biden said in May of last year, speaking to the nation from the Roosevelt Room on May 24 after another school shooting, that time Uvalde. But Biden did, again,

have to comfort a nation that remains both exhausted from the drumbeat of news of mass shootings, yet lacking sufficient interest in doing much to give itself a pause. And there is no reason to think Biden won't have to use that damned word again.

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What to Know About the TikTok Security Concerns

Billy Perrigo is a correspondent at TIME based in the London bureau. He covers the tech industry, focusing the companies reshaping our world in strange and unexpected ways. His investigation ‘Inside Facebook’s African Sweatshop’ was shortlisted for the 2022 Orwell Prize.

TikTok’s CEO Shou Zi Chew faced an extensive grilling from U.S. lawmakers at a congressional hearing on Thursday, amid a new wave of concerns about the app’s ties to China and the security of U.S. citizens’ data.

The House Energy and Commerce Committee hearing came after the Biden Administration indicated it may ban the app outright in the U.S. if its Chinese owner, Bytedance, refused to sell its stake in TikTok to an American company.

TikTok, which has 150 million users in the U.S. alone, has emerged as one of the most contentious elements in the U.S.’s deepening rivalry with China. The Biden Administration, along with

lawmakers on both sides of the House and Senate, say they are concerned about the implications of Americans' data being accessed by the Chinese state, which could present a national security risk. China's national security law requires companies to turn over customer data if requested by Beijing.

Watch: *TikTok CEO Testifies Before the House Energy and Commerce Committee*

The controversy over TikTok is driving yet another wedge between the U.S. and China. Beijing said Thursday it would oppose any effort by Washington to force a sale of the app, suggesting that such a move could lead Chinese investors to retract their investments from the U.S. economy.

Ever since before the Trump Administration first threatened to ban TikTok in 2020, the company has denied accusations that it has close ties to the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) and that U.S. citizens' data are at risk. It says it has since invested $1.5 billion dollars in a project to ensure sensitive user data is kept on U.S. soil, cannot be accessed from Beijing, and is subject to U.S. government audits. "TikTok has never shared, or received a request to share, U.S. user data with the Chinese government," Shou said in written testimony ahead of Thursday's hearing. "Nor would TikTok honor such a request if one were ever made."

His efforts have done little to dispel concerns in Washington. While the congressional hearing on Thursday was reminiscent of earlier grillings on the hill of tech CEOs, with lawmakers often using props—large printouts or TikTok videos displayed on a big screen—to make their points, the unity of condemnation coming from both sides of the political aisle was remarkable. "We do not trust TikTok will ever embrace American values," Cathy Rodgers, the Republican chair of the House Energy and Commerce Committee, said. "TikTok has repeatedly chosen the path for more control,

more surveillance and more manipulation. Your platform should be banned."

Here's what to know about the debate over TikTok.

What is TikTok accused of?

The Biden Administration and the U.S. intelligence community are reportedly concerned about Americans' data falling into Chinese hands because of the belief that this data could help China conduct influence operations aimed at the American public. TikTok's demonstrable ability to amplify content directly to millions of users, including many children and teens, appears to have American officials worried that the Chinese state could compel TikTok to covertly influence the U.S. public.

Read More: *Why the U.S. and Other Countries Want to Ban or Restrict TikTok*

In 2019, the Guardian reported that TikTok had instructed its moderators to censor videos mentioning topics seen as controversial by the CCP, including the 1989 Tiananmen Square massacre and Tibetan independence. TikTok has said those guidelines are no longer in use, and in late 2022 videos of anti-government protests in China spread widely on the app.

"Our intelligence community has been very clear about China's efforts and intention to mold the use of this technology using data in a worldview that is completely inconsistent with our own," the U.S. deputy attorney general Lisa Monaco told the *Wall Street Journal* last month.

The director of the National Security Agency, Paul Nakasone, said earlier this month he was "concerned" about TikTok's ability to influence the U.S. cultural conversation. "It's not only the fact that you can influence something, but you can also turn off the

message, as well, when you have such a large population of listeners," he told the Senate Armed Services Committee.

These fears have not only been stoked by politicians and the national security community, but also TikTok's competitor Meta, which has sought to portray the platform as a danger to American children deserving of a ban, the *Washington Post* reported. Meta first launched Instagram Reels, a clone of TikTok, in 2020 when it appeared the Trump Administration may have been on the brink of banning the app.

Do the security concerns about TikTok hold water?

It's impossible to say with certainty, because they are predictions about the future. But as well as there being little evidence (publicly available, at least,) that TikTok has engaged in narrative control on behalf of the CCP, there is also no evidence to show that TikTok has a clandestine connection to the Chinese state. "I've been trying for years to find any links to the Chinese state," the journalist Chris Stokel-Walker, who has written a book about TikTok's rise, wrote in BuzzFeed News this week. "I've spoken to scores of TikTok employees, past and present, in pursuit of such a connection. But I haven't discovered it. I can't say that link doesn't exist … But none of us has found the smoking gun."

Still, TikTok has a long list of very real privacy scandals under its belt. In December 2022, the company admitted that employees had spied on reporters using location data, in an attempt to track down the source of leaked information. Those employees were fired, TikTok's parent company ByteDance said. TikTok also reportedly planned to surveil the locations of specific U.S. citizens using location data from their devices, Forbes reported last October.

Read More: *TikTok Has Started Collecting Your 'Faceprints' and 'Voiceprints.' Here's What It Could Do With Them*

TikTok also engages in what some observers have called invasive tracking measures against ordinary users. These tactics include prompting users to let TikTok harvest their phone contacts lists, as a way of connecting users who already know each other on the app. Even if you refuse to give TikTok access to your contacts, it will still prompt you to follow people who have your number in their phone contacts lists.

But these growth-hacking measures are hardly any worse than what other homegrown social media companies like Meta do. And the systemic issue behind those more benign privacy violations isn't TikTok's relationship with China. It's the fact that the U.S. has no comprehensive privacy legislation, allowing social media apps to operate in an effective Wild West when it comes to collecting and monetizing user data. "If you think the U.S. needs a TikTok ban and not a comprehensive privacy law regulating data brokers, you don't care about privacy, you just hate that a Chinese company has built a dominant social media platform," Eva Galperin, the director of cybersecurity at the Electronic Frontier Foundation, wrote on Twitter.

"While Congress has been up in arms about TikTok, it has failed to pass even the most basic comprehensive privacy legislation to protect our data from being misused by all the tech companies that collect and mine it," Julia Angwin, the founder of investigative tech news site The Markup, wrote in a New York Times opinion piece. "When you dig into the national security allegations against TikTok, it is telling that most of the charges could just as easily be levied against the U.S. tech giants."

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Should You Take an Antiviral to Prevent Long COVID?

Jamie Ducharme is a health correspondent at TIME. She covers the COVID-19 pandemic, Long COVID, mental health, vaping, psychedelics, and more. Her work for TIME has won awards from the Deadline Club, the New York Press Club, and the Newswomen's Club of New York. Additionally, she is the author of *Big Vape: The Incendiary Rise of Juul*, which was adapted for a forthcoming Netflix docuseries.

The only guaranteed way to prevent Long COVID is to avoid getting infected by SARS-CoV-2, the virus that causes COVID-19. Recently, however, researchers have found promising signs that certain drugs may reduce the risk of developing Long COVID if they're taken shortly after infection.

Those studies are preliminary, but they raise an intriguing question: Should everyone who gets COVID-19 take medication in hopes of avoiding Long COVID?

Here's what experts say.

Which drugs might prevent Long COVID?

Studies have recently highlighted two promising drugs: Paxlovid and metformin.

Paxlovid is an antiviral authorized to treat COVID-19 among people at high risk of severe disease, including elderly adults and people with underlying health conditions. Last year, researchers found that high-risk people who took Paxlovid within five days of testing positive for COVID-19 were 26% less likely to have Long COVID symptoms after 90 days, compared to people who weren't treated. On Mar. 23, the same researchers published updated data in *JAMA Internal Medicine.* Among a larger group of high-risk people who were tracked for six months—more than 35,000 of whom took Paxlovid—the drug showed the same reduction in risk.

Metformin, meanwhile, is not a classic antiviral; it's long been approved as a Type 2 diabetes treatment. But studies suggest that it may have antiviral properties, potentially limiting SARS-CoV-2's ability to copy itself. In one recent study (which has not yet been peer-reviewed), metformin cut the risk of Long COVID by more than 40% among overweight or obese adults who took it when they had COVID-19, compared to those who didn't take the drug.

I have COVID-19. Should I take an antiviral to prevent Long COVID?

It's too soon to recommend that for the general population. Dr. Harlan Krumholz, a professor at the Yale School of Medicine who is studying Paxlovid as a potential treatment for Long COVID, says even the most promising study results need to be confirmed before they influence medical decisions.

"We zig and we zag on evidence all the time. To simply start telling everybody to start taking a medication" before there's solid data is

overzealous, he says.

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There’s still debate about what causes Long COVID, adds Stefan Sarafianos, a professor at Emory University who studies antivirals. Some experts think remnants of the virus linger in the body and cause long-lasting symptoms. If that’s true, it’s “intuitive” that an antiviral drug could help prevent that outcome—but, Sarafianos says, it’s not clear if that hypothesis is the right one. “Long COVID is a big mystery,” he says.

Despite the unknowns, certain patients may want to pursue Paxlovid prescriptions, says Dr. Ziyad Al-Aly, a clinical epidemiologist at the Washington University School of Medicine in St. Louis and co-author of the *JAMA* study on Paxlovid. For people at high risk of severe COVID-19, who already stand to benefit from Paxlovid, the possibility of preventing Long COVID is an added bonus, Al-Aly says.

But “in people who don’t have risk factors,” Al-Aly says, it’s basically “an evidence-free zone.”

Studies have shown that Paxlovid has minimal effect among lower-risk people up to 28 days after their illnesses began. Krumholz says it’s worth tracking the drug’s effects over a longer period of time, but as of now, there’s no strong data to suggest younger, healthy people should be taking it.

Metformin may be useful for a larger group of people, argues Dr. David Boulware, a professor at the University of Minnesota Medical School and co-author of the study on the drug’s potential

ability to prevent Long COVID. Boulware and his colleagues studied adults ages 30 to 85 who were either overweight or obese. More than 70% of U.S. adults are either overweight or obese, so that includes a large swath of the population.

Boulware personally decided to take metformin when he caught the virus last summer. But, he says, it's one thing for a physician to make a personal choice, or to recommend a drug for a specific patient based on their health profile, and another to make a sweeping recommendation for the whole population.

Dr. Anand Viswanathan, a clinical assistant professor at the NYU Grossman School of Medicine, agrees that it's too soon to recommend metformin to the general public. The research "represents a good early signal," he says. But "we need more studies to corroborate that data before I would vouch for mass use."

That's especially true, Krumholz says, because metformin isn't a classic antiviral. He'd like more information on how it may work against SARS-CoV-2 before recommending it to patients for the prevention of Long COVID.

Is it risky to take Paxlovid or metformin to prevent Long COVID?

Both Paxlovid and metformin are safe, but they come with possible side effects including gastrointestinal issues, muscle pain, and unpleasant aftertastes, as well as rarer but more serious issues.

Plus, Paxlovid interacts with a number of common medications, Viswanathan says, meaning patients may have to pause their other treatments while they take it. That may be worthwhile for someone who could get seriously ill from untreated COVID-19, but it's a harder sell for someone who may not even benefit from taking Paxlovid.

Widespread Paxlovid use could also theoretically raise the risk of antiviral resistance, Sarafianos says. Drug resistance happens when pathogens mutate enough to stop responding to the medications meant to tame them. Overuse or misuse of drugs (such as by missing doses or stopping treatment early) increases the chances of that happening.

Although resistance to Paxlovid is not currently a major concern, Sarafianos says it is possible—potentially more so if the drug is widely used, since some patients might not take Paxlovid properly because of its unpleasant aftertaste and side effects.

It's "a numbers game," Sarafianos says. "As more people take [a drug], the more possibilities there are to come up with a resistant strain."

Viswanathan adds that there could be shortages if everyone with COVID-19 starts clamoring for these drugs, regardless of whether they really work. "These medications are a limited resource, they have side effects, and we should be prioritizing their use for the intended patient populations that would actually get the [proven] benefit," Viswanathan says.

The situation may change in the future, as more research comes together. But for now, experts say, it's best to use Paxlovid and metformin in the ways regulators have authorized them.

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The Scariest Part of the New U.N. Climate Report? What Scientists Can’t Predict

Justin Worland is a senior correspondent at TIME in the Washington, D.C. bureau. He received Covering Climate Now's inaugural Climate Journalist of the Year award in 2022, among other awards.

The scariest part of a landmark new report on the science of climate change may be what scientists don’t know.

On Monday, the International Panel on Climate Change (IPCC), the U.N.’s climate–science body, released the final volume in a series of reports outlining experts’ latest understanding of the science of climate change. The report declared the science of climate change “unequivocal” and warned that even with urgent action we will continue to face a dramatic uptick in catastrophic events—from droughts to floods—that have become tell-tale signs of a rapidly warming world.

But, for all that scientists are able to lay out clearly and confidently, the part that gives me the greatest pause is the brief section on what you might call “known unknowns”—potential outcomes that

scientists know could happen even if they don't know when or understand exactly how. Near the middle of the 37-page summary for policymakers, which outlines the report's key themes, scientists explain the "likelihood and risks of unavoidable, irreversible or abrupt changes."

It's striking both how close we may be to crossing a number of points-of-no-return and how little we know about those points.

Take the Atlantic Meridional Overturning Circulation (AMOC). This system of ocean currents may sound wonky, but it is a key regulator of temperatures in the Atlantic Ocean and, in turn, maintaining land temperatures, particularly in North America. In the latest report, the IPCC says that scientists have "medium confidence" that AMOC will *not* abruptly collapse before 2100. But, if it did, we would quickly face remade weather patterns, extreme stress on ecosystems, and distrupted "human activities."

Another known unknown addressed by the IPCC is the magnitude of sea level rise. In high-emissions scenarios in which countries abandon climate commitments, global average sea levels are expected to rise up to one meter (about three feet) by 2100. But because the science of rapidly melting ice sheets remains difficult for scientists to understand, that number could also plausibly end up being two meters in the same time frame, a dramatic difference that could mean the difference between destruction and survival for coastal communities around the globe.

The report summarizes these known unknowns in dry, scientific language: "the likelihood of abrupt and/or irreversible changes increases with higher global warming levels. Similarly, the probability of low-likelihood outcomes associated with potentially very large adverse impacts increases with higher global warming levels." In other words, the more it warms the more likely we are to experience unpredictable catastrophic changes.

Regardless of how its worded, the stakes could be world-changing: the loss of entire ecosystems, the rapid remaking of regional climates, and the destruction of entire regions.

Climate events of this magnitude are typically referred to as tipping points, singular climatic events that within an instant can reshape our understanding of climate systems. These tipping points have received attention because of how inherently scary they are, but they aren't the only terrifying known unknowns.

It receives just a fleeting mention, but the new report lays out how the future becomes more difficult to predict as climate change proceeds. In short, climate change impacts that scientists might be able to project today will become more difficult to predict when they intersect with other climate effects. The report gives food insecurity as example. Food insecurity could drive changes in agricultural practices, which would in turn affect the climate.

"With further warming, climate change risks will become increasingly complex and more difficult to manage," says the report. "Multiple climatic and non-climatic risk drivers will interact, resulting in compounding overall risk and risks cascading across sectors and regions."

Flipping through three decades of IPCC reports, it's easy to see how the science has evolved, growing more certain and more urgent with every passing report. The IPCC is not expected to publish another report for at least another six years. In that time, the science will evolve, as will the on-the-ground impacts of climate change that humans experience. It's also likely that global warming will surpass the 1.5°C mark identified by scientists as a danger zone where we might expect some of these tipping points to occur. By then we should know more about these known unknowns, too. We can only hope that the knowledge brings relief, not further fear.

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India’s Opposition Party Says Rahul Gandhi’s Conviction Is ‘Flimsy and Cooked Up’

Astha Rajvanshi is a staff writer at TIME based in the London bureau. She covers international news and affairs with an eye on India and neighboring countries. She received the Matthew Power Literary Reporting Award and a Fellowship from the Institute of Current World Affairs.

Rahul Gandhi, the de facto leader of India’s main opposition party, was expelled from Parliament after being criminally convicted of defamation on Thursday.

“These are flimsy & cooked up charges,” Praveen Chakravarty, a spokesperson for the Indian National Congress, told TIME in a statement. Congress has accused the government of Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi of “plain vendetta” after Gandhi spoke against the Indian billionaire tycoon, Gautam Adani, in Parliament.

On Thursday, a local court in the western state of Gujarat convicted and sentenced 52-year-old Gandhi to two years in prison over a

speech he made during an election rally in 2019, during which he said: “Why do all thieves have Modi as their surname?”

Gandhi’s remarks referred to the Prime Minister along with Nirav Modi, a fugitive diamond tycoon, and Lalit Modi, the banned founder of the Indian Premier League. The defamation claim was filed by Purnesh Modi, a member of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), who said that Gandhi’s comment “defamed the entire Modi community.”

The Congress spokesperson told TIME that the party will be pursuing legal and political action. “We will appeal the conviction in higher courts but understand that the process is the punishment,” Chakravarty said. “We will take this issue to people through mass agitations & door-to-door contact programs.”

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Shortly after, Gandhi was also expelled from the lower house of Parliament and lost his seat as a state representative for Southern Kerala. According to an official statement issued on Friday, his disqualification is due to Indian parliamentary rules which mandate that those convicted of a crime and sentenced to two or more years in prison cannot serve as members of the lawmaking body.

Gandhi will not be serving any immediate jail time after the court granted him bail to file an appeal within 30 days. He can resume his parliamentary seat if he wins his appeal. However, if he loses, he will not be able to contest any Indian elections for the next eight years.

“Mr. Gandhi remains unperturbed and unflailing in his pursuit of truth and justice and will continue to raise important issues against the Modi government fearlessly,” said Chakravarty.

The BJP did not respond to TIME's request for comment.

The events come ahead of a national election just over a year away, to be held in April and May 2024, which will see Modi and the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party seeking a third term in office.

The scion of a political dynasty that dominated Indian politics for decades, Gandhi resigned as the Congress party president after the 2019 election. Last year, the party appointed Mallikarjun Kharge as its new leader.

Although political analysts view Congress winning the next election as unlikely due to Modi's steady popularity, Gandhi has nevertheless grabbed the attention of Indian voters in recent months. Last year, he undertook the months-long Bharat Jodo Yatra, or "Unite India March," during which he walked nearly 2,500 miles across the country in an attempt to reconnect with Indian voters.

In recent months, he has also given fervent speeches in Parliament attacking the Modi administration over its close ties with Adani, who was accused of pulling "the largest con in corporate history" by U.S. short seller Hindenburg in January. Gandhi seized the Adani scandal as an opportunity to talk about India's stagnant economy and high unemployment rate.

Elected BJP officials have accused the Congress party of having a "feudal mindset" and "a sense of entitlement" for criticizing the conviction. "Law is equal for everyone," the Indian education minister, Dharmendra Pradhan, told reporters at a press conference. He also accused Gandhi of "abusing" oppressed castes by calling those with the last name Modi "thieves."

Read More: *India's Manhunt for a Hardline Sikh Leader Leads to Internet Shutdowns and Global Protests*

Legal experts in India expressed surprise over the court's verdict. Unlike in the U.S. and the U.K., defamation is a criminal offense in India, not a civil one. On Twitter, one constitutional scholar posted that the defamation charge against Gandhi couldn't stand in court unless an individual showed a direct reference to themselves, rather than a "generic class of persons."

Apar Gupta, the executive director of an Indian non-profit, the Internet Freedom Foundation, posted on Twitter: "Rahul Gandhi's disqualification for a conviction in a criminal defamation case is another blow against Indian democracy. One does not even need to be fond of him as a person or support his politics to understand it."

He continued, "the colonial law has been twisted and used as a weapon to target an opposition member and bar their participation in Parliament. "

The Congress Party said it is confident that Gandhi would get a stay on his conviction in court. "We retain our faith in India's judiciary and are confident that truth will triumph," Chakravarty told TIME.

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Donald Trump Is the First President Ever Criminally Charged. Others Have Come Close Though

Olivia B. Waxman is a staff writer at TIME. She covers history and education.

Donald Trump will make history once again—this time as the first former U.S. president ever to be criminally indicted.

A Manhattan grand jury voted to indict the 45th President in a case involving his alleged hush-money payment to former porn star Stormy Daniels, according to his lawyers and media reports. Daniels says she and Trump had an affair; Trump denies this.

“Like all things with Trump, it’s unprecedented,” says Barbara Perry, a presidential historian at the Miller Center at the University of Virginia. President Ulysses S. Grant was technically the first President to be arrested—for speeding on a horse and buggy in 1872. But the Trump case will go down in history as one of the biggest political scandals in American history—even if the charges relate to the seemingly mundane offense of bookkeeping fraud.

Criminal history, as it pertains to U.S. presidents, is pretty brief.

In terms of the seriousness of the scandal, Perry argues the Watergate scandal is the closest parallel because it was the first time a President resigned. President Richard Nixon stepped down in 1974 after tapes revealed he participated in the cover-up of the 1972 break-in at a Democratic National Committee office in the Watergate complex. Several Nixon advisors, from the White House lawyer to the Attorney General, served prison time. While the Department of Justice initially argued that a sitting president couldn't be indicted on a criminal charge, Nixon was not assured that protection post-presidency, so his successor Gerald Ford pardoned him. As Ford put it, "My fellow Americans, our long national nightmare is over." But a Sept. 1974 Gallup poll reported 53% of Americans thought the pardon was the wrong thing to do, and it's one of the reasons Ford was voted out of office in the next election.

Read more: What Was the Biggest Political Scandal in American History? 7 Historians Make Their Picks

Arrests of major federal officials have an even longer history. Secretary of the Interior Albert Fall was convicted of bribery in

1929 for accepting hundreds of thousands of dollars in Liberty Bonds after allowing a private company to lease oil reserves in Wyoming known as Teapot Dome. Back then, TIME called Fall "the first felon in a President's cabinet in U.S. history." As biographer Robert Dallek explained the significance of the scandal, "People in the government were selling the administration to the highest bidder, using their government power to exploit bad positions to make a lot of money." Fall served under President Warren G. Harding from 1921-1923, and Harding came to be viewed as corrupt. Increased press scrutiny revealed that he had a mistress. The stress of the scandal is thought to have led to his fatal heart attack in August 1923.

Bill Clinton was the last President who was close to facing criminal charges. Paula Jones, a receptionist, claimed she suffered emotional damage after Clinton exposed himself to her in a hotel room in May of 1991, back when he was the Governor of Arkansas, and sued for sexual harassment. In *Clinton v. Jones*, "the Supreme Court sets a precedent that a president can be sued for actions allegedly taken before he becomes president—that in turn led to an impeachment," says Perry. President Clinton did have to pay civil damages to Paula Jones, and the suit brought to light the other womanizing he had engaged in, including a roughly two-year relationship with former White House intern Monica Lewinsky. However, while he was impeached in Dec. 1998 and acquitted in Feb. 1999, the scandal didn't impact his popularity. His approval ratings kept going up.

There are similar worries that charging Trump could further boost his popularity with his sympathetic base. Yet Clinton wasn't trying to run for re-election; the impeachment happened in his second term. Trump, however, is trying to stage a comeback after losing the 2020 election. With GOP rivals already making hay of the scandal—Florida Governor Ron DeSantis quipped, "I don't know what goes into paying hush money to a porn star"—it remains to be seen whether criminal charges would help or hinder his 2024 bid.

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8 Ways to Apologize Well

Angela Haupt is a health and wellness editor at TIME. She covers happiness and actionable ways to live well.

Apologies are how we smooth over conflicts and repair relationships, prove our character to others, and coexist as imperfect beings. Yet few of us know how to do it well—or have the bravery to do so.

“A good apology builds bridges. It heals wounds,” says Marjorie Ingall, coauthor of the new book *Sorry, Sorry, Sorry: The Case for Good Apologies*. “It’s also really hard. Apologizing is a courageous act, because we’re overcoming all of our own animal instincts and all of our own self-protectiveness when we do it.”

Sincere apologies can be difficult to nail. Everyone wants to feel like a good person, which can lead to defensiveness—we talk ourselves out of the idea that we did something wrong in order to safeguard our sense of self. “We immediately turn to excuses, justifications, reasons why the victim provoked us,” says Karina Schumann, an associate professor of psychology at the University

of Pittsburgh who's researched the barriers to apologizing. "And if we're able to convince ourselves of that, then that can—in our minds—preclude the need for an apology." Or, perhaps we don't care enough about fixing a certain relationship to apologize, she adds. We might also overestimate how uncomfortable delivering the apology will be, or assume that it won't work.

But sincere apologies bring a host of benefits to the person delivering the message and the one receiving it. They help solidify relationships and mend trust, both of which can lower stress and improve mental health. "It's really unhealthy to hold onto shame and guilt and not try to work through your emotions around negative behaviors and harmful acts you've committed," Schumann says. Plus, some research indicates that those receiving apologies can experience improvements in blood pressure and heart rate, as well as increased activation of empathy-related brain regions that set the stage for forgiveness and reconciliation.

If you're ready for your mea culpa moment, here are eight keys to apologizing well.

Don't rush into it

Apologies are better late than early, says Cindy Frantz, a social psychologist at Oberlin College who has researched how timing influences apology effectiveness. "What we found is that there can be a temptation to offer an apology quickly," she says. "It's an effort to shut the whole incident down and move on. And that benefits the perpetrator, but it doesn't meet the needs of the victim."

You can't deliver an effective apology until and unless the injured party believes that you fully understand what you did wrong, she says. "If the apology comes before that, it's not going to be seen as sincere."

Be open to a variety of formats

If you're dealing with a relatively minor offense, consider apologizing over text message or in person, Ingall suggests. Emails often work well for more serious situations. "And if you really screwed up, there's something very powerful about a stamp and nice stationery and a pen," she says. Just don't issue your apology via social media, which can be humiliating for everyone involved.

Another rule of thumb: "When you're apologizing to someone, you have to give them an out," Ingall says. "You don't want somebody to feel trapped by you—they need an escape route." Don't block the pathway out of someone's work cubicle, for instance, or lean into their car window so they're unable to pull away.

Start with specific words

Use the words "I'm sorry" or "I apologize." Opting instead for phrases like "I regret" or "I feel bad about what happened" often results in non-apologies, which "have the vague contours of an apology, but don't actually get there," Ingall says. (See: The classic "sorry if you were offended" or "sorry, but…" approaches.) Plus, saying you regret something puts the focus on you and your emotions, when it needs to center squarely on the wronged person's feelings.

Accept responsibility

Why should you apologize if you're both at fault? That's exactly the question many people struggle with, Schumann says—and certainly, there often is dual-responsibility. "But I like to encourage people to really focus on taking responsibility for the parts of the conflict that they're responsible for," she says. Avoid the urge to phrase it as, "I'm sorry I did this, but you also did that." The inclination to do so is "normal, because we want to contextualize

our behavior and call attention to the fact that we're also hurt," she says. But save it for later on in the conversation.

Emphasize certain words

Always choose your words carefully when apologizing, advises Lisa Leopold, an associate professor of English language studies at the Middlebury Institute of International Studies at Monterey who has analyzed the language of public apologies. Avoid conditional phrases, like "if" or "may"—as in, "I'm sorry if anyone was offended," which suggests that perhaps there were no victims. "But" is another misstep. It undercuts your message, she notes.

It's crucial to use "I" or "my" while apologizing, Leopold adds. For example, say "I'm sorry for my outburst," rather than "I'm sorry for the interaction this morning." And always use the active voice. "If you say something like, 'I apologize for what happened,' well, 'what happened' is something you have no control over," she says.

It can also be helpful to utilize intensifiers such as "very," "truly," "sincerely," "deeply," and "extremely." These can "enhance the language of an apology," Leopold notes.

Be clear about how you plan to repair things

One of the core elements of an apology is making reparations. Sometimes, Schumann says, that will be possible in a direct way: You broke their favorite wine glass? Buy them a new one. Spilled coffee on their dress? Pay for the dry-cleaning.

If that's not feasible, consider more symbolic forms of repair. For example, if you hurt someone's feelings with a critical comment, make it clear that you misspoke. "Sometimes you can't repair what's happened, but you can think about the relationship moving forward," she says. "How can you communicate a promise to behave better?" It's important for the other person "to hear that this

is not going to continue…and they can trust you to improve your behavior in the future.”

Communicate sincerity

A variety of things can help make it clear your words are coming from the heart, Schumann says. First, the apology should match the severity of the offense. If you’re apologizing for infidelity and say, “Sorry about that, love,” you won’t come across as very genuine, she notes; however, those words might be adequate if you’re 10 minutes late for dinner.

You should also aim to put yourself in the other person’s shoes and convey that you understand what you did was hurtful to them, and the consequences they dealt with as a result. It can be helpful to listen first and ask them questions about their vantage point, Schumann advises. “That might allow you to really understand what they’re going through, and therefore be able to offer a more authentic, victim-focused apology.”

Don’t expect forgiveness

An apology is a starting point. Particularly with severe offenses, the person wronged will often need time and space to heal, and it’s important not to pressure them. It can be tempting to follow up with something like, “What’s wrong? I apologized—how long are you going to hold onto this?” Instead, Schumann suggests checking in like this: “I understand this isn’t going to fix everything, and I want to continue to do whatever I can to make this right by you. I hope that, even if you’re not ready to forgive me, you’re open to working with me to get us to a point where we can move forward.”

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Erdogan's Political Reign Has Never Been on Shakier Footing

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Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan was mayor of Istanbul when a devastating earthquake hit Izmit in 1999, killing more than 17,000 people and devastating the country's economy. The government's shambolic response to the natural disaster created an opportunity for Erdogan to burnish his credentials as a capable and compassionate leader, setting the stage for his election as premier in 2003.

Erdogan has maintained an iron rule ever since, outliving economic downturns, refugee crises, corruption scandals, protests movements, and even a coup attempt. But with the May 14

presidential and parliamentary elections just around the corner, seismic shifts both literal and figurative are threatening to upend the president's grip on power for the first time in two decades.

The most obvious challenge to Erdogan's reelection is his botched response to the earthquakes that rocked Turkey and Syria in February, which claimed over 45,000 lives and internally displaced some two million people across ten provinces. Accounts from the ground broadcast over social media told a story of overwhelming government incompetence, from delayed rescue efforts and assistance to affected areas to misuse of available resources to an inability to quell unrest and establish public order. Many Turkish citizens also blame Erdogan's consolidation of power and populist policies for allowing shoddy construction to grow unchecked. While the president may be able to weaponize his control of the media and government spending to contain the immediate political fallout, the damage to his credibility as a steady hand is already done.

Read More: *How Erdoğan's Obsession With Power Got in the Way of Turkey's Earthquake Response*

The second and perhaps more significant challenge to Erdogan's rule is a main opposition bloc that is for the first time in ages united behind a joint presidential candidate, People's Republican Party (CHP) leader Kemal Kilicdaroglu. Kilicdaroglu has surprised everyone by managing to consolidate much of Turkey's notoriously fractious opposition under the umbrella of the Nation Alliance, which comprises social-democrat, center-right, right-wing, and Islamist parties, at the same time as he's expanded support for the bloc.

To have a shot at beating Erdogan, Kilicdaroglu needs to win over the pro-Kurdish People's Democratic Party (HDP) and its left-wing Labor and Freedom Alliance—the election's kingmakers—without alienating his biggest coalition partner, the Turkish nationalist and

conservative Good Party (IP). This is a tricky balancing act but one he's proving capable of pulling off. The CHP leader successfully mended his relationship with the IP after a public row over his engagement with the HDP, and the HDP has already signaled its support for Kilicdaroglu by refraining from fielding a candidate of its own.

Recent polls accordingly show Kilicdaroglu leading the president, although neither candidate likely to attain a first-round win. As things stand, the HDP is also likely to hand the anti-Erdogan Nation Alliance a slim majority in parliament. Critically, an opposition victory in the parliamentary elections would boost Kilicdaroglu's chances in the second round of the presidential contest.

Of course, it's too early to say whether Kilicdaroglu will be able to hold the coalition together and sustain his momentum. For example, the HDP could make demands that are non-starters for IP such as cabinet posts or regional autonomy, which would undermine opposition unity.

Erdogan is also a skilled politician with ample experience leveraging his bully pulpit. Having already dismantled or hollowed out most independent checks on his power, including the military, the judiciary, and the media, the president will use any means at his disposal—however heavy-handed or anti-democratic—to tilt the scales in his favor. At a minimum, he will ramp up state-financed handouts to buy votes and try to link the HDP with the outlawed Kurdistan Workers' Party (PKK) to paint his chief rival as a terrorist sympathizer. Should he feel cornered enough, he could jail opposition leaders under false pretenses and criminalize dissent. Yet nothing he does at this point is likely to earn the president much genuine support outside of his core voter base—even if fear tactics and repression help him secure another term.

One thing is clear: In the 20 years he’s been in power, Erdogan’s political fortunes have never been on shakier footing.

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Scientists Solve the Mystery Behind the Oumuamua ‘Alien Spacecraft’ Comet

Jeffrey Kluger is an editor at large at TIME. He covers space, climate, and science. He is the author of 12 books, including *Apollo 13*, which served as the basis for the 1995 film, and was nominated for an Emmy Award for TIME's series A Year in Space.

The astronomers operating the Pan-STARRS1 telescope on the island of Maui were not expecting to hit cosmic paydirt on Oct. 19, 2017—but they did. On what was otherwise an ordinary night of skygazing, they suddenly spotted what is easily the oddest comet ever detected. Its high speed—87 km per second (54 mi. per second)—and highly elliptical angle indicated that it originated from deep space, the first known interstellar object ever to enter our solar system. It was cigar shaped and, as comets go, tiny—just 115 m (377 ft.) long and 19 m (62 ft.) wide.

Most important, the comet—which was dubbed Oumuamua (Hawaiian for “a messenger from afar arriving first”)—actually accelerated during the latter part of its transit, more than the gravitational influence of the sun could explain. That left even sober scientists to speculate that the object might actually be an

alien spacecraft, speeding up under its own power during its barnstorming of our solar system.

In the years since Oumuamua's discovery, most people have put aside the E.T. talk, but no one has yet explained how, in fact, the object defied traditional cometary physics and hit the gas as it was leaving our solar system. Now, at last, a new paper in *Nature* might have the answer—and it has everything to do with molecular hydrogen.

Every comet that passes through our solar system speeds up on the way out. For one thing, as it swings around the far side of the sun, the solar gravity gives it a sort of whipcrack push. What's more, dust on the surface of the comet outgasses due to solar heating, providing a natural jet that adds even greater acceleration. But Oumuamua was too small to have any surface dust—denying it the glowing halo, or coma, that circles the body of common comets as well as creating the comet's characteristic tail.

"When astronomers looked for common signatures of outgassing activity, they couldn't find them [on Oumuamua]," says Jenny Bergner, professor of chemistry at the University of California, Berkeley, and lead author of the new paper. And while Oumuamua did pick up some energy from the sun's gravitational push, calculations showed its increase in speed was too great to be explained by that factor alone.

"The most mysterious thing about Oumuamua was this very significant non-gravitational acceleration," says Darryl Seligman, a post-doc in astronomy at Cornell University and the co-author of the paper

One possible answer, Seligman says, was what's known as the Yarkovsky effect, a phenomenon by which small bodies like asteroids—or tiny comets like Oumuamua—absorb photons from the sun and re-radiate them in a kind of propulsive plume. But this

effect too was too small to account for the degree of Oumuamua's acceleration.

That left three possible explanations: propulsion provided by nitrogen, carbon monoxide, or molecular hydrogen (H2). All three of these gasses are present in comets and all three are what is known as hypervolatiles. "They really want to be in the gas phase all the time," says Bergner, "but sometimes they can be frozen."

When Oumuamua was in deep space, the hypervolatiles were frozen indeed, exposed to temperatures as low as -269ºC (-450ºF). In theory, as the comet approached the sun, those hypervolatiles could have warmed up and outgassed as plumes, giving Oumuamua the push it needed to explain its extra-gravitational acceleration. The same process would take place on other comets, but they are too large to be affected much by such a subtle nudge. A tiny comet like Oumuamua would be a different matter

In the course of their work, Bergner and Seligman ran computer models to determine both the overall composition of the comet and its so-called "budget" of hypervolatiles—how much carbon monoxide, nitrogen, and H2 would be present. They also conducted thermal modeling to estimate how the change in temperature from deep space to the warmer inner solar system would affect those materials. On the whole, they determined that the quantities of carbon monoxide and nitrogen onboard Oumuamua would be too low to explain the outgassing and acceleration. But H2 would be a different matter.

Oumuamua, like most comets, is rich in water. Before the comet entered the solar system, the extreme cold of deep space would cause the water to freeze into ice in what is known as an amorphous state. Rather than the solid, crystalline structure of ordinary ice, amorphous ice is porous, dotted by pockets. Exposure to deep space would have a second effect on the ice too—with cosmic radiation causing some of the H2 in the H2O molecules to

break away. That H2 would collect in the pores of the amorphous ice, like fuel in tiny fuel tanks. When Oumuamua entered the inner solar system, it warmed up just enough for the ice to convert to its crystalline state, essentially closing the pockets and forcing the H2 out of the comet, providing the propulsive push that explained the acceleration.

“When the water matrix has enough energy, it rearranges to a more stable and more compact configuration,” says Bergner. “In the process, you lose those pores and the hydrogen can escape through the surface.”

So question answered, problem solved and, alas, no alien spacecraft in the mix. Bergner, Seligman, and other astronomers will be looking for similar small and dark comets when the National Science Foundation’s Vera C. Rubin Observatory goes into operation in Chile’s Atacama desert in 2025, with a specific charge to spend part of its observation time looking for hydrogen outgassing from comets. Before 2017, astronomers did not even know that a species of comet like Oumuamua existed. Now, thanks to the Rubin Observatory and the astronomers who will make use of it, we’ll learn more about their behavior, composition, population, and more.

“The main takeaway is that Oumuamua is consistent with being a standard interstellar comet that experienced heavy processing [in space],” said Bergner in a statement that accompanied the release of the paper. If one Oumuamua exists, many more should be found.

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Deadly Waterborne Bacteria Are Surging Because of Climate Change

Alice Park is a senior health correspondent at TIME. She covers the COVID-19 pandemic, new drug developments in cancer and Alzheimer's disease, mental health, HIV, CRISPR, and advances in gene therapy, among other issues in health and science. She also covers the Olympics, and co-chaired TIME's inaugural TIME 100 Health Summit in 2019. Her work has won awards from the New York Press Club, and recognition from the Deadline Club. In addition, she is the author of *The Stem Cell Hope: How Stem Cell Medicine Can Change Our Lives*.

Climate experts have long warned about the myriad ways that warming temperatures can negatively affect human health. Now that global temperatures are predicted to increase by 1.5°C by the 2030s, that risk is becoming increasingly real.

One long-held prediction that appears to be coming true—according to the results of a new study—is how climate change can potentially expand concentrations of bacteria that thrive and spread

through warm U.S. waters and cause an infection with a particularly high fatality rate.

In a paper published in *Nature Scientific Reports*, scientists at the University of East Anglia in the U.K. analyzed infections that were reported to the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) from 1988 to 2018 caused by *Vibrio vulnificus*, a type of bacteria that lives in sea or brackish waters warmer than 68°F. *Vibrio vulnificus* kills approximately 20% of the healthy people, and 50% of those with weakened immune systems, that it infects—though it's rare in the U.S. (for now). People can get infected either by eating raw shellfish such as oysters or by exposing small cuts or wounds to waters where the bacteria live; eating infected shellfish can cause diarrhea vomiting, fever and chills, while infected wounds can lead to serious skin infections. There is no strong evidence that antibiotics can control the infection, but doctors may prescribe them in some cases.

The researchers focused on wound-based infections, since those are easier to pinpoint to specific locations. They then created models predicting the pattern of new infections over the next few decades. One model assumed a more sustainable trajectory, in which emissions would be relatively low and the rise in global temperatures would be slower. Another assumed more of a worst-case scenario, in which containing emissions and addressing warming were low priorities for nations around the world.

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In the first model, the scientists concluded that *Vibrio vulnificus* infections would likely extend as far north as Connecticut as soon as half a century from now, in 2081. Under the latter model, these

infections would be be reported in every eastern U.S. state by then. Currently, only about 80 cases are reported in the U.S. each year; by 2081, that could jump to anywhere from 140 to 200 cases under the worst-case scenario, the authors say. Current trends, they add, are somewhere between the two ranges they used.

Those cases would be the result of a continued northward creep of *Vibrio vulnificus* infections, extending from the Gulf coast, where infections have historically been concentrated, all the way to the waters off of Pennsylvania and New Jersey, where infections have been reported since 2018. This expansion represents not just outlier cases, but the concentration of cases, which is increasingly moving higher up the coastline as temperatures warm. “We’re seeing the core distribution of infections extending to areas that traditionally have very few and very rare cases,” says Elizabeth Archer, a PhD researcher in the School of Environmental Sciences and the lead author on the study. “But these areas are now coming into the main distribution of infections.”

The reason why has to do not only with warming sea temperatures but warming air temperatures as well, which are drawing more people to the coasts and bays and into contact with the bacteria.

“The bacteria are part of the natural marine environment, so I don’t think we can eradicate it from the environment,” says Archer. “It’s more about mitigating infections by increasing awareness and improving education about the risk. That means having more tools to alert people if there are particularly high concentrations in certain areas on particular days.”

The National Centers for Coastal Ocean Science, part of the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, for example, has developed models to estimate changing concentrations of *Vibrio vulnificus* in the Chesapeake Bay, Delaware Bay, Gulf of Mexico, and other coastal areas. The models are still for research purposes, but they’re a starting point for future ways to track and

alert people about bacterial surges that could pose a health risk. The European Center for Disease Control and Prevention has a tracker that provides six-day information on *Vibrio vulnificus* concentrations in waters in the region. “We need bigger geographical areas covered by these tools in order to visualize where the risk might be occurring in the near future,” says Archer.

Ultimately, what would help to curb *Vibrio* infections is an index that would allow the public to monitor *Vibrio* levels similar to the way people currently have information about air quality. “Just as we currently have pollen alerts, there could be something similar with *Vibrio*,” says Iain Lake, professor of environmental epidemiology at University of East Anglia and senior author of the paper. He notes that the bacteria are so sensitive to temperature changes that concentrations could bloom even after a day of warmer water, so consistent monitoring and alerts are critical.

Lake says the expansion of *Vibrio vulnificus* is concerning for public health since the bacteria is now invading waters closer to heavily populated areas, such as New York and Philadelphia. “Everyone can get a *Vibrio vulnificus* infection,” he says. “But the more interaction there is between warmer waters and people, the more the bacteria can move into populations such as the elderly and those with other health conditions, who are more vulnerable to infections.”

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The Person I Became After My Father's Death

Chung is the author of the memoirs A Living Remedy and All You Can Ever Know

After my father dies, I become, for a time, someone I do not recognize. Entire weeks are all but lost to me, scooped out of my once airtight memory. Our rental term ends two months after the funeral, and when we move into another house, I hardly remember packing or unpacking.

I don't know how to ask for leave from my job. I tell myself that I can't afford to take unpaid time off anyway. The truth is that I have always been able to work, and now I learn that grief is no hindrance to my productivity. I bank on this, even feel a kind of twisted pride in it. It doesn't matter to me whether I take care of myself, because I do not deserve the care. All my parents wanted was to spend more time with us, to see us more than once a year or every other year, and I never found a way to make it happen, and now my father is dead. When other people—my husband, my friends—try to tell me that I am not at fault, I barely hear them. Punishing myself, keeping myself in as much pain as possible, seems like something a good daughter should do if it is too late for her to do anything else.

There is a flurry of activity in the run-up to the publication of my first book. My publisher sends me to conferences, schedules readings and interviews. I am grateful, and frankly surprised, to be getting any attention at all, and so of course I tell everyone that I am more than ready to do my part, to help the book succeed. I know how important it is to my career, and I feel enormous pressure not to let down any of the people who are working so hard on it. I want it to have a fighting chance, too, because it is a book in which my father still lives.

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When I stop working, it's not to rest but to head to a soccer game or swimming lesson, or plan a Girl Scout meeting, or chaperone a school field trip. I treat myself like a machine, which makes it easy for the people I work and volunteer with to see and treat me that way too. "It's been hard," I say with a shrug, when asked how I'm doing, "but I'm hanging in there." One day, my older child calls me out on my usual choice of words.

"How come you always tell people that you're 'hanging in there'?" she asks.

Well, I think, a bit defensively, *because I am.* Am I not still doing what needs to be done: getting up every morning and going to work, taking care of my family, saying yes to anything anyone asks me to do? I haven't dropped a single ball at work. My publishing team has thanked me for my promptness in replying to their emails, for being *so great to work with.* I am an expert at grieving under capitalism. Watch and learn.

All the while, I keep daydreaming about walking into traffic.

From the moment the thought pushes its way into my grief-muddled brain, I know that I could never act on it. It's not that I want to hurt myself—it's that I cannot seem to work up any remorse when I think about no longer being alive. Nor does the thought frighten me, as it always did before. *What if you didn't have to feel this way anymore?* my mind proposes, in moments that are deceptively calm, moments when I am not sobbing in the shower or screaming in my car because I cannot scream at home. *What if the pain could just end?*

As a child, I knew that I was not permitted to indulge in the hyperbolic or sarcastic statements other kids made about wanting to die, because my father would erupt. Toward the end of sixth grade, my teacher had everyone in my class write a fake will; my most charitable reading is that the exercise might have been intended to help us identify the things that were most important to us as we moved from elementary into middle school, symbolically leaving our childhoods behind. Most of my classmates made light of the task—*I hereby bequeath my Game Boy to my little brother, because he always steals it anyway*—but I remember little of what I wrote in my will, only my father's fury over the assignment. "You're 12 years old!" he yelled. He threatened to call my teacher. And then all the fight went out of him, his voice numb as he told me about being 21 years old and witnessing the death of his favorite cousin. The two of them had shared an apartment in a Cleveland high-rise, and one night my father came home to find him about to jump from their window. He pleaded with him, tried to stop him, but his cousin leaped before he could reach him. Dad had always blamed himself.

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It takes me months, after his death, to realize that I am not *fine*, or *hanging in there*. I go to see my doctor for a long-overdue physical and break down in the exam room, sobbing as she hands me one flimsy tissue after another. I leave with a referral to a counseling practice, but manage to find one closer to my house, close enough to walk, because I know I'll come up with a million reasons to reschedule or cancel otherwise.

During one early session, my therapist, the first Asian American therapist I've ever worked with, asks me if I know what has kept me from harming myself as I flounder in grief. I don't even have to think about the answer. "My family," I say. My children, who have no idea how dark my thoughts have become. My husband, who keeps our household afloat on days when I cannot manage anything beyond the workday. My sister, who faithfully checks on me every week. My mother, whom I text and call so often it probably annoys her. "The people I love still need me."

"And you still need them," she says. "You don't want to leave them."

I feel the truth of these words in my bones, try to keep them close.

Slowly, I find my footing again. When I catch myself faltering, fumbling in the dark for a thread to follow back to the person I was before, the thing that often keeps me from despair is talking with my mother. Sometimes I wish that she would voice some concrete need, ask me to do something for her, but she seems to be taking care of herself—it occurs to me that this might be easier than taking care of both herself and Dad, as much as she misses him. I can sense her sorrow and restlessness, always, but there is a driving, don't-quit vitality about her, even in mourning.

One day, she tells me she has decided to get rid of Dad's lift chair, and one of their old end tables. *I never liked that table, Dad did. I*

am learning that I can make decisions based on what I want—that if I don't like something, I can just make a change. Another day, we discuss whether she might get a dog; it has been a long time since she had one in the house. She sheepishly tells me she used some of the money I gave her to buy new miniblinds. "That's perfect!" I say. I don't care how she spends it, as long as it's useful.

Read More: *How I Found My Desire to Live After My Wife Died*

It's hard for either of us to imagine her remarrying. But as she begins to plan the next stage of her life without my father, I realize that I can picture her living out her own days in peace—and, more important, it seems she can as well. My heart lifts when she tells me that she is planning a trip to Greece with two of her friends from church, intending to use what's left of my father's life-insurance payout to make her first-ever trip outside the country. They will visit monasteries and holy sites, see the sights, and swim in the sea; the trip is to be part pilgrimage, part escape.

After that adventure, I think, I will help her consider what she wants her new life to look like. I can be her sounding board, if nothing else. I know her ties to Oregon are strong after four decades there, but maybe someday she'll decide that she wants to move closer to us on the East Coast. Or maybe we will relocate to the Northwest and provide more support to her once our kids are done with school. There's no need to figure everything out now, I tell myself. Dad has been gone only a matter of months. We have time. Mom has time.

I feel certain she has never doubted, for a second, that living is worth it.

Chung is a TIME contributor and the author of ALiving Remedy, *from which this essay was adapted*

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Inside Ukraine’s Push to Try Putin for War Crimes

Simon Shuster is a senior correspondent at TIME. He covers international affairs, with a focus on Russia and Ukraine. For his first book, *The Showman*, he reported inside the Ukrainian President’s compound in Kyiv as the Russian invasion unfolded.

In the office of Andriy Smyrnov, the deputy head of Ukraine’s presidential administration, the wanted posters spread across the desk serve as a kind of mission statement. They show the faces of five Russian officials, led by President Vladimir Putin, next to a list of the charges Ukraine has leveled against them: aggression, war crimes, crimes against humanity. “We had these printed as a reminder,” Smyrnov says while pacing around his desk on the third floor of the presidential compound, one floor down from the chambers of his boss, President Volodymyr Zelensky. “There’s no alternative to putting Putin on trial,” he says.

The question is where, and under whose authority. As the top aide to Zelensky on judicial matters, Smyrnov, 42, has spent the past year charting a path to an improbable destination: a courtroom,

somewhere, with Putin in the dock. Every step has been painstaking, with Ukraine's closest allies often blocking the way. But Smyrnov, who has no experience in international law, has made surprising progress. Last fall, he says, "Nobody even wanted to talk to us about a tribunal. Now look at how quickly the civilized world is waking up."

On March 16, investigators working with the UN Human Rights Office reported that Russian forces committed crimes against humanity, a rare rebuke from a UN body against a sitting member of the UN Security Council. The following day, the International Criminal Court in The Hague (ICC) issued a warrant for Putin's arrest, charging him in connection with another alleged war crime: the mass deportation of Ukrainian children to Russia. Less than two weeks after that, the U.S. set out a plan to put Putin on trial for the crime of aggression, which some scholars describe as the root of all war crimes.

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None of these developments are likely to achieve justice as Zelensky, Smyrnov, and their team have envisioned it. The ICC's warrant will be toothless unless Putin travels to a country willing to arrest him, and the U.S. plan for an "internationalized national court" remains vague; some legal experts say it would be easy for Putin to sidestep or ignore. But it all feels like a breakthrough to Smyrnov and his colleagues. "When it came to creating a tribunal," he says, "there were a lot of issues on the agenda that seemed unattainable half a year ago. In reality, they were well within reach."

Before the invasion, Smyrnov's role in the presidential headquarters mostly involved pushing paper. He worked on judicial reforms and helped prepare documents for Zelensky's signature. A lot of that changed on the morning of Feb. 24, 2022, when Russian missiles began raining down on cities across Ukraine. Holed up in their bunker beneath the presidential compound, Zelensky and his aides realized that their judicial system could soon be hijacked. If the Russians seized control of the courts, they could begin issuing legal decisions that would undermine Zelensky's authority or legitimize the puppet government that Moscow wanted to install in his place.

To prevent that, Smyrnov rushed to the server room of a Kyiv courthouse and, with help from an officer of Ukraine's security services, broke through the door. Once inside, they unplugged the court's internal computer network—the judicial equivalent of blowing up a bridge to thwart the advance of enemy tanks. "In terms of separation of powers, that's probably not what you should do," he says, pulling up photos he took that day of the courthouse servers, their wires ripped out and dangling. "But these were extraordinary times."

By early April, the President's legal department shifted to a new challenge. The Russian military's retreat from the Kyiv region

exposed gruesome atrocities in places they had occupied. The streets of Bucha, a suburb of the capital, were littered with the bodies of dozens of civilians; hundreds more were later found in mass graves around town. In the wake of that massacre, Zelensky's calls for justice intensified."Accountability must be inevitable," he told the UN on April 5, 2022, the day after he saw the evidence of war crimes in Bucha for himself.

Under international law, the Security Council can create a tribunal to prosecute war crimes, as it did after the wars in Yugoslavia and Rwanda in the 1990s. But that would not work in the case of Ukraine, because Russia, as a permanent member of the Security Council, holds a veto over all its rulings. As they looked for an alternative, Smyrnov and his team found themselves studying the Nuremberg trials of Nazi war criminals and reviewing evidence from crime scenes and mass graves around Ukraine. "I used to get a kick out of horror movies," Smyrnov says. "But after some of the things I've seen, after some of the exhumation reports, any horror movie feels like a joke."

Ukrainian investigators have received nearly 80,000 reports of war crimes and opened thousands of cases against Russian military personnel accused of committing them. But when it comes to prosecuting Putin, Smyrnov and his team discovered, Ukrainian

courts do not have the authority. It would take an internationally authorized tribunal to overcome the legal immunity Putin enjoys as a sitting head of state, says David Scheffer, a former U.S. ambassador-at-large for war crimes.

At first, the ICC in The Hague seemed like a logical venue. But unlike 123 other countries, Ukraine and Russia never ratified the treaty that created the ICC in 1998. Neither did the United States. President Trump even sanctioned the ICC leadership in June 2020 for their attempts to investigate the use of torture in Afghanistan.

The Ukrainians decided to push instead for the creation of an ad hoc tribunal focused on holding Russia's leadership responsible for the crime of aggression, which the Rome Statute defines as a war crime. "In this whole gruesome story, the decision to start the war is the original crime," says Christian Wenaweser, Liechtenstein's ambassador to the UN. "It's the crime of the leadership, the ones who ordered the invasion, and we need to have a mechanism to prosecute them for it."

But who would give authority to such a tribunal? Ukraine decided to seek it from the 193 member states of the UN General Assembly; unlike the 15-member Security Council, Russia holds no veto there. Through the spring and summer of 2022, Smyrnov and his colleagues appealed to dozens of foreign countries and international institutions for support. But the talks were often frustrating. Prosecuting the crime of aggression tends to appeal to its victims, like Ukraine, and to smaller countries like Liechtenstein, which does not have a military. The U.S. and other big powers see less advantage in letting foreign courts judge their decisions on when to make war.

Behind closed doors, U.S. diplomats warned Ukrainian officials that a tribunal could hinder Washington's ability to reach Putin in an emergency—if, for instance, the war escalated into a nuclear

standoff, two of the officials said. Others said that it could prolong the war by impeding peace talks. One European official even told his Ukrainian counterparts the tribunal could only be fair and balanced if it included a Russian judge.

Smyrnov found it hard to respond to such arguments without losing his temper. As the evidence of Russian atrocities piled up in agonizing detail, he often fell back on sarcasm. “Let’s just write Putin a greeting card and say, Dude, you’re awesome. We bow our heads. We won’t judge you for your crimes of aggression,” Smyrnov says between pulls on a vape, summarizing a point he has often made to foreign officials. “Or how about we stop being afraid,” he says. “How about we team up and hold him accountable.”

By September, the effort reached what he calls “a psychological plateau.” European institutions and parliamentary assemblies had backed the idea of a tribunal. But with heads of state, Smyrnov says, “we reached the limits of our ability to communicate.” The lawyers asked Zelensky to step up the pressure, and he pushed harder for a tribunal in his talks with foreign leaders. As Ukraine made gains on the battlefield, the prospect of holding Russia to account became easier to imagine.

In January, the European Parliament voted 472 to 19 to support a tribunal's creation. The vote was symbolic, but it gave Kyiv hope that momentum might turn its way at the UN General Assembly, where Ukraine could count on only a few dozen votes. Russia's influence there was one obstacle. But support from the U.S. was also far from certain.

In December 2022, Congress authorized the U.S. to aid "investigations and prosecutions" related to the war in Ukraine. Yet the Pentagon raised objections, concerned about setting a precedent that could put U.S. officials in legal jeopardy. (A decision whether to give intelligence to the ICC for its case against Putin is due to come before President Biden soon, according to the New York Times.)

At the end of March, Smyrnov's goal of an ad hoc tribunal seemed to get a boost from the Biden Administration. In a speech on March 27, America's ambassador-at-large for global criminal justice, Beth Van Schaack, said the U.S. would endorse an "internationalized national court" that Ukraine could establish with support from the U.S. and its allies, not the UN. "This kind of model," she said, would "demonstrate Ukraine's leadership in ensuring accountability for the crime of aggression."

To some legal scholars, the approach looked deeply flawed, as it would still allow Putin to claim immunity as a sitting head of state. "Unfortunately it plays into Putin's hands," says Scheffer, who held the same post as Van Schaack during the Clinton Administration. "Putin and his colleagues can ignore the prospect of prosecution for the crime of aggression." Skeptics view the move as an attempt by Washington to derail the prospect of a UN-authorized tribunal.

But Ukraine sees it as another step on the road to justice. A few months ago, Smyrnov says, the U.S. opposed any tribunal that would hold Russian leaders accountable. The Ukrainians have not given up on the hope of a resolution in the UN General Assembly

that would empower a tribunal under international law, and they plan to keep rallying support for such a vote in the months ahead. “We’ve overcome our fear,” Smyrnov says. “The rest should be easier.”—*With reporting by Julia Zorthian*

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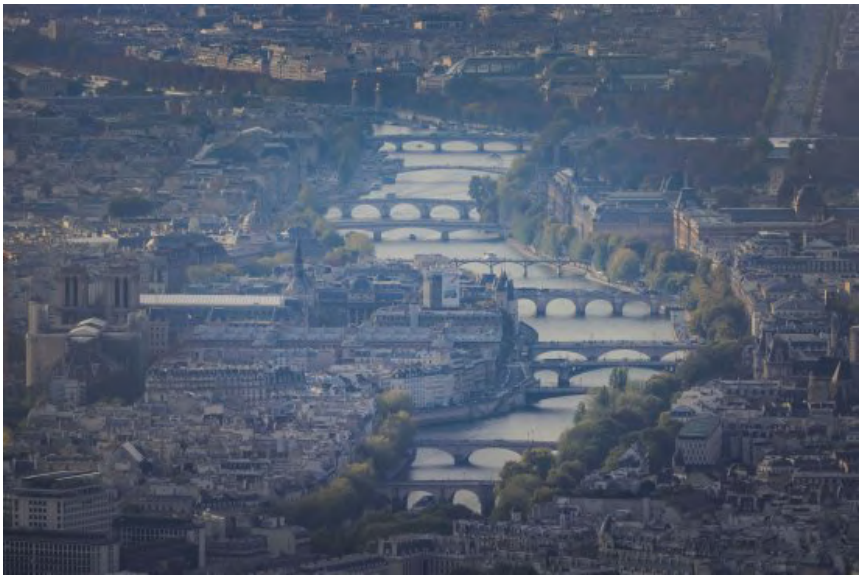
Inside the Billion-Dollar Effort to Clean Up the World’s Most Romantic River

Vivienne Walt lives in Paris and has written for TIME since 2003, from dozens of countries around the Middle East, Africa, and Europe.



For residents of southeast Paris, the construction vehicles rumbling back and forth behind the Austerlitz train station are a loud annoyance that has gone on for too many months. But for city officials—and countless Parisians, they hope—history is unfolding behind the cordoned-off area. After years of thwarted ambitions and vague promises, the French capital, officials say, is set to accomplish a rare feat for a major metropolis: making its once heavily polluted waterway fit for swimming again.

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In February, city officials invited TIME to pass through the metal turnstile behind the cordon, and see up close the cleanup of the Seine—one of the world’s most iconic rivers—which stretches for 481 miles, from Burgundy through Paris out to the sea in

Normandy. Indeed, the river has defined Paris since it was founded by ancient Romans. It was along these riverbanks that merchants in the Middle Ages first set up, creating a settlement that finally dwarfed once bigger rivals like Lyon and Marseilles. And it was on the banks, too, that the world's finest architects constructed the Eiffel Tower, the Notre Dame Cathedral, and the Louvre and Orsay museums—stunning monuments that draw millions of visitors each year to sail down the narrow stretch of the Seine that cuts through the dead center of Paris. Officials are therefore keenly aware of the deeper significance of cleaning up the Seine, seeing it as a way of connecting the modern city to its oldest history. "The Seine," says Emmanuel Grégoire, deputy mayor of Paris in charge of urban planning, "is the reason why Paris was born."

Once the €1.4 billion ($1.5 billion) project is finished—by next spring, if all goes to plan—Parisians will be legally allowed to swim in the river for the first time in a century. (Authorities banned it in 1923 because of high levels of pollution.) "Swimming at the foot of the Eiffel Tower will be very romantic," Grégoire says, before guiding TIME underground into the giant—and decidedly unromantic—rainwater storage tank, crucial to cleaning the Seine.

In recent years, smaller European cities, like Zurich, Munich, and Copenhagen, have opened urban swimming. There are also efforts under way to make swimming possible in Berlin's Spree River and Amsterdam's canals, with frequent meetings among cities to discuss what is required. Yet Grégoire is keen to point out that making the Seine swimmable could mean Paris becoming the world's first giant urban area to have inner-city bathing. "It is a dream," he says.

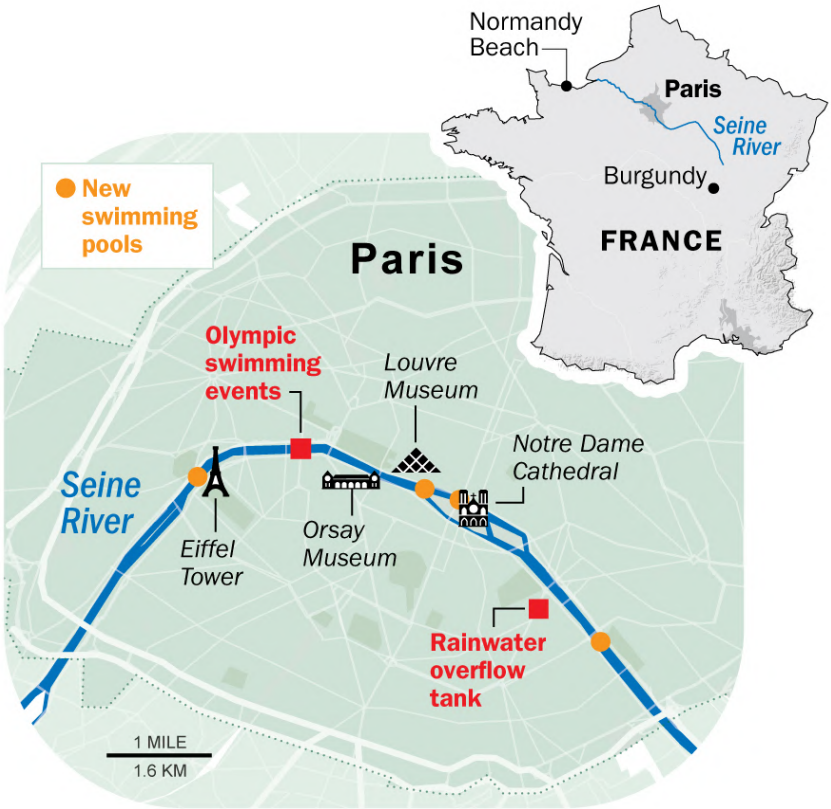
Some believe the Seine's cleanup will also spur similar projects elsewhere. "The Seine River is maybe the most romanticized river in history, in literature," says Dan Angelescu, founder of Fluidion, a water-monitoring tech company based in Paris and Los Angeles, which has taken daily readings of pollution levels in both cities' rivers since 2016. The Seine cleanup, he says, "obviously has a lot of emotional impact on people, and definitely acts as inspiration to others."

Los Angeles, which will host the 2028 Olympics, has sent water and sanitation officials to Paris to study the Seine cleanup. When asked which other major cities are watching how Paris is cleaning the Seine, Angelescu responds, "I think everybody."

But for Parisians, setting a global example may matter less than the tangible benefits of making the Seine swimmable again. There are environmental advantages: officials predict the revival of fish stocks that have dwindled over the decades, as well as the restoration of river foliage. A swimmable Seine could also give Parisians an escape from sweltering summer temperatures; Paris hit a record 108.6°F in 2019. Further, an economic motivation looms large: cleaning the Seine was a cornerstone of Paris' winning bid for the 2024 Olympics, an event that could generate up to €10.7 billion ($11.4 billion) for the French economy and create 250,000 jobs, according to a 2017 study by the Centre for Law and Economics of Sport (CDES) at the University of Limoges in west-central France.

The idea of cleaning up the Seine is hardly new. In 1990, then Paris mayor and later French President Jacques Chirac declared he would launch a major cleanup of the Seine, and swim in it “in three years.” The idea withered over the years, and Chirac died in 2019, his grand ambition unfulfilled.

What makes this time different is the pressing Olympics deadline. When the current mayor of Paris, Anne Hidalgo, presented her winning bid for the 2024 Games back in 2016, she promised that the city, home to 11 million people in the greater urban area, would undergo a drastic environmental upgrade by 2024. Key to her bid was enabling Olympic athletes to swim in the river, as they did when Paris hosted its first Olympics in 1900. “From 2015, we decided we were going to take advantage of the Olympic Games to considerably accelerate the vision,” Grégoire says. “It was a really important part of the candidacy.”



The 10K swimming marathon, the aquatic portion of the triathlon, and one Paralympics swimming event are set to start in the Seine—at a venue built under the ornate 19th century Alexandre III bridge in central Paris. The river will also be used for the marquee opening ceremony: rather than the global norm of using an Olympic stadium, athletes will kick off the Games on a flotilla of boats sailing 6 km (3.7 mi.) through the city—past Paris' most famous landmarks strung along the Seine. "We need to use its monuments, its culture, its history," Paris Olympics head Tony Estanguet told TIME in an interview last year, about the significance of centering the Games on the Seine. Some 600,000 spectators are expected on the riverbanks, more than seven times the capacity of France's biggest stadium in northeast Paris.

A year after the Games end, Parisians will have access to 26 new swimming pools in the Seine, expected to open by 2025, four of them in the city center. The pools will be walled off from heavy boat traffic that carries cargo, garbage, and about 7 million tourists a year.

These changes represent a sharp break from all of Paris soiling its river for centuries. That includes throwing into the Seine the bodies of those killed in the 16th century religious wars between Protestants and Catholics, and in more recent decades discarding TV sets, motorcycles, and other large items in the river; 360 tons of large items are hauled out of the Seine every year, according to the Hauts-de-Seine local government on the western outskirts of Paris. But the biggest source of pollution in modern times has been the dumping of countless tons of wastewater—which includes domestic and industrial sewage—into the river.

Fortunately, the city says that as a result of recent infrastructure upgrades, the amount of untreated wastewater that ended up in the Seine in 2022 was 90% lower than 20 years ago. Despite this progress, pollution is still a problem; last year, 1.9 million cubic meters of untreated wastewater was spewed into the Seine.

Dumping all of this into the river, officials say, is necessary to avoid saturating Paris' sewage network and flooding the city when especially heavy rain hits. But the Seine has paid the price over the years.

Some 150 years ago, Napoleon's city planner Georges-Eugène Haussmann carried out a massive remake of Paris, putting into place infrastructure that may have been cutting-edge in the 1860s but is now largely antiquated, says Samuel Colin-Canivez, chief engineer for major sanitation works in Paris.

The Haussmann approach, for example, involved a combined sewer system, in which waste and stormwater runoff from the streets are collected in the same network. Since the 1980s, efforts have been made to modernize: spillways have been automated and fitted with valves. That has drastically cut down the amount of untreated wastewater going into the Seine, but has not entirely eliminated the problem.

That combination of older sewage systems and new ones plus pipes carrying everything from drinking water to fiber-optic cables means there is a labyrinth of infrastructure running under Paris' sidewalks and streets—Colin-Canivez calls it "a little museum." Figuring out how to divert excess rainwater amid this jumbled mess, so that domestic and industrial sewage is not flooded into the Seine, has been the costly and complicated engineering challenge.

Read More: *Paris Buried a River 100 Years Ago. Now The City Needs To Resurface It to Combat Climate Change*

The planned solution is centered on building the giant underground rainwater storage tank in southeastern Paris, which lies behind the cordoned-off construction site near the Austerlitz train station. There, a steep spiral staircase gouged into the ground opens into a giant, cavernous hole, walled with cement. When TIME visited in

early February, two earthmovers were busily digging deeper and deeper, their lights illuminating the darkness, and their engines drowning out conversation.

The structure is mammoth, equivalent to roughly 20 Olympic-size swimming pools, capable of holding up to 45,000 cu m (more than 10 million gal.) of rainwater. Once completed by next spring, it will measure 50 m (164 ft.) wide and 34 m (111.5 ft.) deep, and have one crucial job: to hold runoff water during a rainstorm, preventing it from overwhelming the city's sanitation network, and thereby having untreated waste flow into the Seine, as currently happens.

Once the project is completed, a tunnel will link the rainwater tank (or *bassin*, as the French call it) to the bank directly across, diverting it from the sewage system. From there, it will be released slowly into the sewer network, then treated downstream in Paris' sewage-treatment plants, before finally passing into the river, all aided by the natural downhill flow.

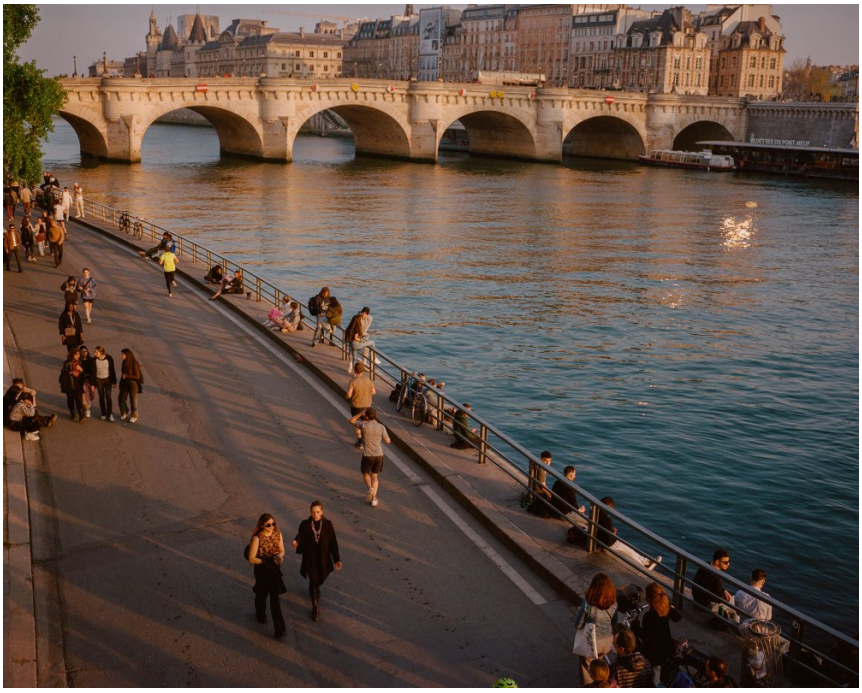
The obstacles Paris faces in transforming its river are the same in old cities elsewhere, including in America. The U.S. set a goal

under the 1972 Clean Water Act to make all rivers and lakes swimmable and fishable by 1983.

Yet 40 years past that deadline, the plan is far from complete, with some blaming outdated monitoring equipment and lax standards. There is a reason that it's taken so long: most of the world's largest cities were built long before modern sanitation networks were knit into urban planning. "You cannot put in a whole new sanitation system. It's ridiculously expensive," says Robert Traver, a leading urban-river specialist and engineering professor at Villanova University in Philadelphia. That city, for example, has had a plan for years to transform its section of the Delaware River and make it swimmable; much like the Seine in Paris, the river cuts through the city.

But decades of budget cutting and politicking have slowed progress. "We have a 20-year plan, and at the end of the 20 years, we have another 20-year plan," Traver says. "Whether it is ever going to happen, I don't know." Looking over the engineering plans for the Seine with TIME, he says, "Nothing in Paris' plan is unique. But to *do* it is unique."

Yet cleaning the Seine might not be the final challenge for Paris officials. Parisians will need to feel safe enough to swim in the 26 swimming pools along the Seine that will open after the Olympics. Public confidence in the cleanup is not certain, given years of *E. coli* and enterococci bacteria in the water, and the possibility that a particularly heavy rainfall could contaminate parts of the river.



Last summer, hydrologists measuring fecal bacteria in the Seine at the Olympics' planned river venue in central Paris found that 90% of samples were already clean enough for swimming, according to city officials. The city is also hopeful that three pools built more recently along the La Villette canal in eastern Paris, which opened for swimming in the summer of 2016, can help build public confidence that the Seine can be safe for dips. Grégoire says the water is tested daily for bacteria. "We manage to have the pools open for swimming 95% of the time," he says.

Still, when the polling agency Ifop asked 1,000 French people in 2021 what they thought of the Seine, 70% described it negatively, with some calling it dirty, polluted, and smelly.

For now, city officials are not deterred. They believe their plan will only build on the progress made in recent years to upgrade waste treatment—and make the Seine swimmable nearly all of the time. "Our goal, really a philosophy, is that we have to stop polluting. It's a major global issue," Grégoire says. "By making the Seine swimmable, that is the best of the best examples."

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How Frank Gehry Changed Buildings—and Cities—Forever

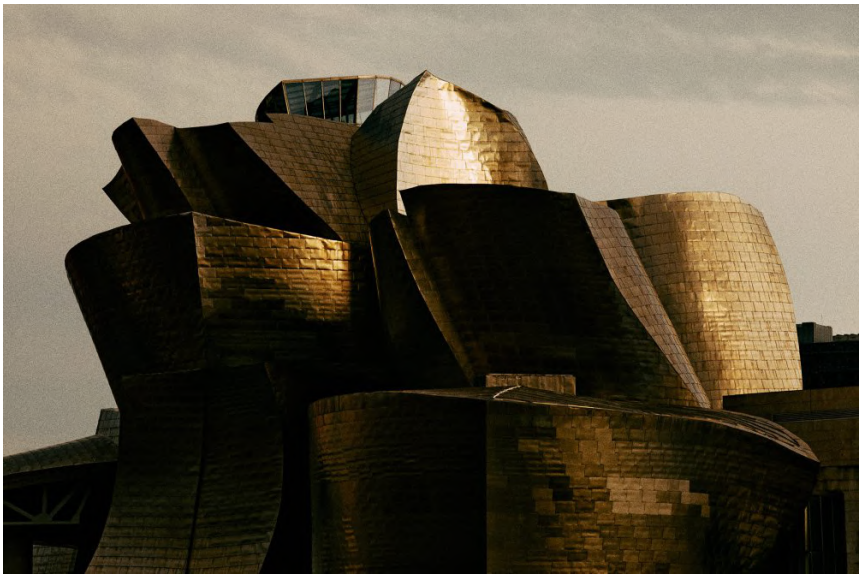
Belinda Luscombe is an editor at large at TIME, where she has covered a wide swath of topics, but specializes in interviews, profiles, and essays. In 2010, she won the Council on Contemporary Families Media Award for her stories on the ways marriage is changing. She is also author of *Marriageology: the Art and Science of Staying Together*.

Frank Gehry wants to build a park in Los Angeles. Not just a normal park on empty land; that's for lightweights. Gehry wants to take chunks of the legendarily unlovely Los Angeles River, a 51-mile engineered waterway mostly lined with concrete, and suspend parks over them. It sounds like a pipe dream, or in this case more of a channel dream; it's expensive, unprecedented, structurally complex, and anathema to many of the locals. But Gehry, 94, has made a career of overcoming such obstacles and, in the process, transforming cities.

Skepticism was also the initial response of officials in charge of selecting the architect for the Guggenheim Museum in the northern

Spanish town of Bilbao, upon seeing the extremely rough models Gehry presented in 1991, in one version of which a tower was represented by an old bottle. “There was a lot of ‘Oh my God, what?’” says Juan Ignacio Vidarte, the director general of the gallery, who was at the meeting where Gehry made his pitch. “But after trying to understand, there was the unanimous decision that this was the right project.”

Gehry won the competition with a design that looks from some angles like a silverized Spanish galleon and from others like a prayer circle of titanium nuns. The finished building not only put Gehry on the map globally, and Bilbao on the map globally, but also became that very rare thing: a cultural artifact that was a classic as soon as it appeared. The officials behind the plan to revive Bilbao had hoped to get 500,000 people a year to visit. In the first three years after its 1997 opening, they got 4 million, and have had 21 million in the years since.



Partly because of that museum, and partly because of his string of pioneering edifices that followed, Gehry is now regarded as the most significant North American architect of his era, and perhaps the most celebrated living architect in the world. He has buildings on almost every continent, and shows no sign of stopping. He still heads into the office—and swims—every day. Construction will

soon begin on his tallest building ever, in his birthplace of Toronto, and has just finished on one in Santa Monica, Calif., his home since the ’60s. A recent study in the *Harvard Business Review* claims he is the only architect whose buildings deliver the promised return on investment. And he’s got plenty of fire left, talking smack about how Santa Monica “builds a lot of high-level crap,” leading that ambitious charge for the riverway, and hopping on a plane to Bilbao for a fiesta.

“I think it’s a lot of happenstance,” Gehry says of his success. He’s not particularly interested in being an oracle; he leans into his Canadian diffidence, perhaps to disarm clients who are expecting a starchitect. He’s not invested in the complex geometry he favors becoming the prevailing style. His working theory of how to create worthwhile structures is simple: “I don’t think you have to spend egregious amounts of money to make buildings that are good for the community, good for our world, that are interesting, and that are humanly accessible,” he says. “I don’t think you have to pay a lot extra. You just have to want to do it.”

Nevertheless, standing on the third floor of the Guggenheim during its 25th–anniversary celebrations in October 2022, even Gehry seemed a little awed. “When you look at your old buildings, you’re very critical of every little detail,” he says, looking around. “And I love it, I think. I find I love it.” Even more, he loves how vibrant Bilbao now is, compared with when he first visited in 1991. The streets are buzzing. “There’s a whole feeling of life that’s different,” he says. “It makes me feel good that we contributed to that.”

Even 30 years ago, Gehry’s success seemed very unlikely. In 1991, the year he won the Guggenheim commission, he was known for his quirky home in Santa Monica, a bunch of fish sculptures he now calls kitsch, and some oddball local structures. His most promising project, a new concert hall for the Los Angeles Philharmonic paid for by the Disney family, was in the limbo

Hollywood calls “turnaround.” Bilbao changed everything. “They were making accusations that [Disney Hall] was unbuildable,” says Vidarte. “So we said, ‘Well, we can prove them wrong.’”

Every great movement starts with discontent, and Gehry’s was that he couldn’t figure out how to build what he could draw. “I was looking for a way to express movement,” he says. He found Modernism cold and post–Modernism reductive. Inspired by fish, he landed on curves. “I got into fish because they are millions of years old, they express movement, and they have an architectural quality,” he says. But fish are slippery; he’d send builders detailed plans and mathematical calculations for sinuous walls and they’d follow them closely, yet the two halves wouldn’t meet.

While traveling, he wondered how the curves of plane fuselages were fabricated, which led him to CATIA, the software the French aerospace company Dassault used to design aircraft. Digital Project, the software that Gehry’s office developed out of CATIA, now used by many of his peers, enables his team to iron out any wrinkles—or in Gehry’s case, add them—before the builders break ground.

His 135-person office (Gehry barely knows how to use a computer) produces sometimes hundreds of digital iterations before they arrive at the combination of shapes and forms that meet all the necessary criteria. Having crunched the input from each of the project’s many consultants, Digital Project then breaks those shapes into buildable structural elements, and produces data to allow factories to fabricate those elements. When the process is complete, and it can take a while, there are no surprises during construction.

Gehry loves music. He has always had artists as friends, but his circle has expanded to musicians, including Gustavo Dudamel, Herbie Hancock, and Daniel Barenboim. He especially likes the way jazz players improvise around themes. His design process could be likened to structural jazz; he messes around with form

over and over, getting the building to turn this way and that, iterating until he finds the version he wants to put down.

The software also enables Gehry to control costs. Once he has broken down the structural elements, he has a method for estimating how much the building will cost, based on volume, floor area, and exterior surfaces. Much has been written of the totality of Gehry's vision—as one Bilbao Guggenheim employee put it, they can't change so much as a fork in the restaurant without the approval of his office—but his obsession with costs is an equal plank of his success. "That's my ego; I gotta do that," says Gehry about bringing things in on budget. It may be that he learned the hard way that if he wants people to embrace his design ideas and way of building, he has to have a spotless budgetary record. He's still smarting over Disney Hall cost overruns. "I have a letter from the county people that we delivered the building for [its budget of $207 million]," he says. "Several board members that tried to control it wasted $150 million. That's all documented now, but I got blamed for it, as you can imagine."

Gehry's are among a tiny proportion of projects—0.5%, according to figures collected by Bent Flyvbjerg, a management professor at Oxford University and IT University of Copenhagen—that deliver on time and on budget and provide the economic benefit that they were intended to, whether it was to bring in more foot traffic, make transport more efficient, or elevate a city among tourists, investors, or developers. "What Frank Gehry accomplished in Bilbao and elsewhere is astonishing," says Flyvbjerg, whose book on the economics of building projects, *How Big Things Get Done*, analyzed cost data on 16,000 built structures from the past 87 years, including very mundane projects. "Nobody is doing what he's doing. Nobody has done these crazy things with materials."

The budget for the Guggenheim was $100 million, and it cost $97 million—and that's with a titanium exterior. Vidarte puts that down partly to Basque industriousness, but also to the fact that the local

builders learned to trust Gehry's methods and he learned to trust that local officials weren't trying to cheap out. The Bilbao model, however, may not be replicable. Dozens of eager civic officials have come to the region since 1997 to find the secret lever that would catapult their once industrial cities into desirable cultural destinations. Pioneering buildings have been commissioned across the globe, in such underloved metropoles as Ordos, China; Dresden, Germany; Valencia, Spain; and Cincinnati, hoping to catch some of the Bilbao magic. None have had as much success.

While Gehry's memory for names sometimes fails him—he has a right-hand architect, Meaghan Lloyd, who acts as his memory bank—his curiosity does not. When he was very young, Gehry's grandfather used to read to him from the Talmud. The religious part never stuck, he says, but the way of looking at the world did. "The first word in the Talmud is *Why*?" he says. "That whole religion is based on curiosity. I love that about what that meant for what I was gonna do."

Long in a position to be picky about his clients, Gehry now tends to choose those who both pique his curiosity and give him a high level of autonomy. He finds houses to be taxing. ("I like people; I just don't like being in the middle of their personal lives.") And big commercial developers are too inflexible. ("It's very hard to convince them to work the way I work.")

If he gets his way, Gehry Partners will not carry on under his name once his curiosity peters out. He hopes the people who work at the firm, who include his son Sam, 44, will forge their own paths. But Gehry has no plans to retire. "I suppose the clock will stop when it wants to," he says. In the meantime, he's going to surround himself with the folks he likes best—the disciplined improvisors. "I love hanging out with people that don't know what they're doing or why," he says. "And then they do it."

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Cheryl Strayed Will Always Be Here for You

Lucy Feldman is a senior editor at TIME, where she oversees coverage of books and authors. She is co-editor of TIME's Women of the Year franchise and a member of the TIME100 editorial team.

On the edge of Wallace Park in Portland, Ore., there is an unremarkable house with a camellia shrub out front. The house is painted a bluish gray now, but it might have been another color before. Cheryl Strayed is standing on the sidewalk in the rain with a smile on her face, conjuring a memory. This is where she took part in a yard sale in 1995, immediately after she—now quite famously—completed a 1,100-mile solo hike on the Pacific Crest Trail. At the time, she was a 27-year-old aspiring writer with 20¢ to her name. She sold whatever she could, including a pencil sharpener to a man who rode in on a bicycle. The man invited her to dinner with some friends, and later that night, Strayed met the person she would marry.

Strayed sees them everywhere: little signs, small reminders. It’s one of the things that define her writing, that ability to draw connections—whether between a yard sale and the life she’s built

with her husband, or between a cry for help from a reader and a lesson she's learned from her own past.

Strayed, 54, has built a career on her dual abilities to tell the whole, ugly truth about herself and to empathize with others, creating a space for self-acceptance. *Wild*, the 2012 memoir of her Pacific Crest Trail journey, told the story of the sudden loss of her mother to lung cancer when Strayed was 22; her subsequent struggles, including a heroin habit and a divorce; and the hike that brought her back to herself. That book, which was adapted into a 2014 film starring Reese Witherspoon, has sold more than 4 million copies worldwide. It also launched Strayed's "accidental" career as a public speaker, for which she has traveled the world teaching writing and speaking to people about the great dreams and traumas of their lives, offering whatever wisdom and encouragement she can.

More from TIME

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It was a fitting shift. Before *Wild* made her a household name, Strayed was going by another one: Sugar. In 2010, two years before *Wild* shot her to literary stardom, Strayed took over the advice column "Dear Sugar" for the online literary magazine the Rumpus. It was a no-pay job answering reader letters in the voice of a woman with a checkered history first dreamed up by the writer Steve Almond, and he was ready to pass the mantle. For two years, as Sugar, Strayed anonymously responded to letters seeking advice on everything from whether to have children to how to overcome jealousy. Instead of offering the practical guidance given by most advice columnists, Strayed treated each missive like an essay,

sharing bits of her personal story to make broader points about the beauty and agony of being human.

A collection of the columns, *Tiny Beautiful Things*, was published just a few months after *Wild*. Strayed and Almond launched a podcast, *Dear Sugars*, in 2014. Nia Vardalos adapted *Tiny Beautiful Things* into a play in 2016. And now, on April 7, Hulu will premiere a television series of the same name. Strayed executive-produced and helped write the series, with *Little Fires Everywhere* alum Liz Tigelaar serving as showrunner. With their team, they created the story of Clare (played by Kathryn Hahn and, in scenes from the past, Sarah Pidgeon), a mother whose life is crumbling when she's asked to take over as the columnist Sugar.

Sugar is, well, sticky. Her story keeps getting remade, and Strayed couldn't shake her if she tried. She and Almond stopped making their podcast in 2018; the Rumpus column was already long done. But strangers never stopped writing to her. They found her personal email or wrote to the old "Dear Sugar" address, seeking a piece of her wisdom. So she started a monthly newsletter. Giving advice is part of her now. The writer and the persona are inextricably linked. And it's precisely because they—both Sugar and Strayed—have lived through dark times, erred, and never claim to have all the answers that the advice is so potent. "I'm not some wise guru who's like, here's how to live," Strayed says, ambling along on our rainy walk. "I'm right down there in the muck with you."

Tigelaar likes to say that adult Clare in the emotional *Tiny Beautiful Things* is an alternate-reality version of Strayed, one who never hiked the Pacific Crest Trail and never wrote *Wild;* now 49 and devastated that she hasn't fulfilled her promise as a writer, she drinks too much, she creates chaos, and her marriage, her work, and her relationship with her kid are all suffering. But, divergent as their present-day realities may be, the Clare character and Strayed share the same history: both married the wrong person too young,

both lost their mothers to cancer during their senior year of college, and both fell into self-destruction.

There is a scene in *Tiny Beautiful Things* when Frankie (the mother of young Clare, played by Merritt Wever) calls Clare home from college. She resists—she's busy, she has work and class and a life on campus—but Frankie insists. We see Clare enter the house where she grew up with her mom and her brother Lucas, the table set for an unusually formal dinner. Her mother is wearing lipstick and a nice dress. She made spinach lasagna and bought ice cream for dessert. Clare fumes. "I can't just come home just because you miss me," she says. This is when Frankie tells her children: she's going to die.

"I get chills even saying this to you," Strayed says. "That was straight from my life." She had the surreal experience of sharing the story of how she learned of her mother's illness in the writers' room for the series, then watching the actors play out the scene. The same thing happened with *Wild*. "Who does this?" she says. "It's like, OK, people, now you're going to re-enact Cheryl's 10 most painful moments, and Cheryl's going to sit there and watch, sometimes over and over."

Strayed being Strayed, she found something heartening in the scene. Watching young Clare storm into the house with her selfish, early-20s attitude, Strayed recognized that any young woman

trying to establish her independence might behave the same way. She couldn't have known what her mother was about to reveal. Observing Pidgeon step into the character, Strayed says, "I feel such a sense of gentleness for the younger version of myself … It's the most specific and bizarre form of therapy."

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This is the story that she has carried with her for more than 30 years. It was the subject of her first book, the 2005 novel *Torch*, of *Wild*, of so many important moments in the "Dear Sugar" column and *Tiny Beautiful Things* in all its forms. With the show, Strayed emphasizes that she wanted to tell a "true story" about grief. Clare's problem is not that she hasn't moved on from her mother's death, she explains. A primal loss like hers is a trauma that re-emerges again and again. When Strayed had her first child, she had to reckon again with her grief, and when she turned 45 and outlived her mother, she did again.

She likens grief to a box you'll hold forever—what it means to you is determined by how bravely you look into it. "Anyone who reads my work or sees the show knows how very much I have turned my deepest sorrow into beauty," she says. "That's what grief is. If we work really, really hard, we can get to that place."

The rain is coming down harder, so I set our course toward a coffee shop I know nearby. With the glowing storefront in sight, Strayed suddenly stops, looking downward. I follow her gaze. I see a penny in the middle of the sidewalk, wet and a little grimy. She sees another sign from the universe: there are good things here. "I've had all the luck," she says, urging me to take it. Instead, I suggest we leave it for the next person to find, so she bends down to touch a finger to the surface, transferring some of her good fortune.

Shaking off the wet as we enter the café, I realize the mistake I've made. There it was: my chance to claim a little piece of Strayed's magic for myself. That's what we congregants of Sugar do. We take her words of encouragement and sympathy, her tough love and her powerful example, her belief in humanity, and we tuck them in our pockets and hold onto them.

Inside, we sit down and continue the conversation. Strayed tells me she's working on another memoir, a project she's been wrestling with for a while. She tells me more about her family, about awkward times when she's been recognized in public, about her writing process. Then, on the walk back to where we started, she brings me right to the spot where we left the penny. It's still there, shinier than before. "It's destiny," she says.

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The Case for Betting on Succession‘s Tom Wambsgans

Judy Berman is the TV critic at TIME. Along with reviewing current television, she writes about the ways in which entertainment and pop culture intersect with our larger social and political realities. Her TIME essay on *Ted Lasso* and modern masculinity won a New York Press Club award in 2022.

Midway through the third season of *Succession*, Tom Wambsgans tells his underling and cousin by marriage, Greg Hirsch, a colorful anecdote from an empire in decline. “Sporus was a young slave boy—he was Nero’s favorite,” Tom (Matthew Macfadyen) explains. “Well, Nero pushed his wife down the stairs, and then he had Sporus castrated, and he married him instead. And he gave him a ring, and he made him dress up like his dead wife.” As Greg absorbs this history lesson, Tom extracts the relevant subtext: “I’d castrate you and marry you in a heartbeat.”

In the HBO dramedy’s much-discussed season 3 finale, Tom sets that prophecy in motion. An ambitious executive at Waystar Royco—the media behemoth led by Brian Cox’s cutthroat octogenarian

patriarch, Logan Roy—and the husband of the boss' only daughter, Siobhan "Shiv" Roy (Sarah Snook), he does the corporate equivalent of pushing his wife down the stairs. When Shiv tells him that she and her brothers Kendall (Jeremy Strong) and Roman (Kieran Culkin) are teaming up to block Logan from selling the business, which would jeopardize what the siblings see as their birthright, Tom turns around and warns Logan. Which raises a question, going into the show's fourth and final season: Could Tom Wambsgans be the successor Logan is looking for?

There are plenty of reasons to doubt him. Tom got an appreciative slap on the back from his father-in-law after betraying the younger Roys, and when the new season opens, he has penetrated Logan's inner circle. But before that he was essentially a satellite of Shiv, always entering rooms unnoticed and offering opinions no one seemed to hear. Capable of delivering floridly profane monologues to—and blowing off sadistic steam at—the slightly more marginal Cousin Greg, Tom the middle-class striver nonetheless seemed content to back his formidable wife.

Read more: *Everything You Need to Remember About* Succession *Ahead of Its Final Season*

Yet it was Shiv who miscalculated in season 3. Just scrupulous enough to question her family's flirtation with neo-fascism and flee, humiliated, when a renegade Ken blasted Nirvana's "Rape Me" at an all-staff meeting as she tried to spin a potentially ruinous sexual-misconduct coverup, Shiv watched Roman replace her as Logan's heir apparent. She took out her anger at this demotion on her husband, in much the same way that he would often unload on Greg, even as Tom spent several episodes panicking that his willingness to take the fall for Waystar's corruption would land him in prison—a sacrifice no one, least of all Shiv, seemed to appreciate. When the couple's ongoing discussions about having kids ended in talk of freezing embryos for up to a decade, followed by Shiv's pillow-talk bombshell—"I don't love you"—it was clear she had pushed him too far.

It would be a mistake, however, to interpret Tom's betrayal as entirely emotional. Sure, in the past he's seemed to be in awe of Shiv (if not quite as impressed with her as she is with herself). You can imagine him burning her because he thinks ruthlessness will win him her respect. But he has also found a way to use the inside information she's thoughtlessly dumped on him throughout their relationship to his strategic advantage. Earlier in the season, when Ken tries to exploit his brother-in-law's scapegoat status to recruit him to the anti-Logan resistance, Tom demurs. "Having been around a bit, my hunch is that you're going to get f-cked," he says. "Because I've seen you get f-cked a lot, and I've never seen Logan get f-cked once."

Foreshadowing aside, that kiss-off not only finds Tom growing the spine to spar with a Roy, but also reveals the siblings' blind spot. Each has their own fatal flaw. As Logan's terminally spacey eldest child, Connor (Alan Ruck), succinctly puts it: "Roman's a knucklehead, Shiv's a fake, Ken's screwy." Collectively, in trying to take down their father and in a project the trio embarks upon in season 4, they share an inflated confidence in their own abilities born of inherited power and privilege. He may fret about the lack of good wine in prison, but Tom is grounded enough to see that Logan has been so successful—and his children haven't—for a reason. He's also more likely to remain invested in the company (or what's left of it should the sale he helped engineer in the season 3 finale go through) once Logan is gone than Logan's kids, who are competing for their dad's love more than anything else.

Tom Wambsgans is a nasty, venal, nihilistic person, as anyone hoping to take Logan's place must be. "Tom would open the gates to the death camps," Macfadyen told *Vanity Fair*. That level of moral flexibility, which serves Tom well as head of Waystar's right-wing news operation, ATN, must surely count as an asset to someone of Logan's particular political convictions. Yet he's not an ideologue or a loose cannon. He's not sanctimonious like Shiv or emotionally volatile like Kendall or prone to humiliating the family through performative onanism like Roman or silly and foolish like

Connor. He isn’t a stiff suit like Logan’s aging deputies Gerri (J. Smith-Cameron), Frank (Peter Friedman), and Karl (David Rasche). Neither is he fickle; it takes years of mistreatment, followed by a flurry of bad decisions, for Shiv to lose his loyalty. Love aside, it seems that he simply wants to back a winner. And for the first time, he’s starting to believe that winner might just be himself.

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Review: BEEF Is Smart, Wild, and Darkly Funny. Why Doesn't Netflix Make Shows Like This Anymore?

Judy Berman is the TV critic at TIME. Along with reviewing current television, she writes about the ways in which entertainment and pop culture intersect with our larger social and political realities. Her TIME essay on *Ted Lasso* and modern masculinity won a New York Press Club award in 2022.

Implicit in every viral road rage video is the same question: What is *wrong* with these people? *BEEF*, a wild black comedy from first-time creator Lee Sung Jin that premieres April 6 on Netflix, delves deep into the sources and fallout of two L.A. motorists' fury. Danny Cho (Steven Yeun) is a struggling contractor wracked with guilt over his immigrant parents' involuntary return to Korea. Amy Lau (Ali Wong) longs to sell her thriving houseplant business and stay home with her husband George (Joseph Lee) and young daughter June (Remy Holt). Their parking-lot showdown leads to a ridiculous chase through suburbia—and then months of ever-escalating attempts to ruin each other's lives.

At first, this simple yet amusing premise seems better suited to a 90-minute feature than a 10-episode Netflix series. But it soon becomes apparent that Lee is doing more than just a live-action *Looney Tunes* bit. In between all the vicious pranks, we get insights into both characters' unhappiness. Desperate to maintain the serene front that's vital to her brand's identity, Amy quietly seethes over a meddling mother-in-law (Patti Yasutake), the manipulations of a billionaire (Maria Bello) who's flirting with acquiring the business, and George's insistence on following in his artist father's footsteps despite his obvious lack of talent. Danny is in debt to a potentially violent cousin (played with wildcard intensity by the artist David Choe) and feels responsible for his lazy, cryptocurrency-obsessed younger brother Paul (Young Mazino). "That's what's wrong with the world today: they want you to feel like you have no control," he rants.

As it progresses, the show fleshes out not just its leads, but also their families, who face stressors and disappointments of their own. The irony is that for all their atrocious behavior, Danny, Amy, and most of the people around them are not, at their core, evil. Each is capable of kindness. But by failing to extend empathy to other characters in pain—and to acknowledge the deep-seated origins of their anger—everyone ends up contributing to a rapidly accelerating crisis.

One of several upcoming TV projects from A24, the studio behind Best Picture winners *Everything Everywhere All at Once* and *Moonlight*, *Beef* is the kind of series—a smart, sophisticated comedy with an ideal cast, artful direction, polished production design—that Netflix has mostly stopped making. It's also the rare show that, like *Everything*, honors the differences in class, ethnicity, and personality that make each of its mostly Asian-American characters unique, rather than flattening them into some idealized exercise in "positive representation." It's a remarkably confident debut from *Dave* and *Undone* vet Lee, and one that keeps upping its ante until the bitter, big-hearted end.

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‘Hago Música Como Si Fuera la Única Persona en el Mundo.’ Bad Bunny sobre Coachella, Hollywood y Superándose a sí Mismo

Andrew R. Chow is a technology correspondent at TIME. His covers crypto, AI, tech regulation, and culture.

Mariah Espada is a reporter at TIME. She covers internet culture, reality TV, and pop culture.

A inicios de marzo, TIME se sentó con la sensación musical mundial Benito Antonio Martínez Ocasio, también conocido como Bad Bunny, mientras se preparaba para actuar en Coachella, el primer artista latino en encabezar el destacado festival de música. Durante una amplia entrevista, Martínez Ocasio habló con franqueza sobre su vida, su música y cómo pasa más tiempo en estos días en Los Ángeles, un lugar al que “siempre soñó ir” cuando era un *chamaquito* (un niño pequeño) mientras crecía. Puerto Rico. También se refirió a su floreciente carrera como actor, junto con la responsabilidad que siente como reguetonero a quien a menudo se le pide que hable en nombre de toda una región.

La siguiente transcripción ha sido condensada y editada para mayor claridad. Para la versión en inglés haga clic aquí.

Actualmente, estamos en el centro de L.A. ¿Te gusta aquí?

Realmente, sí me gusta. Siempre me ha gustado desde que he estado viniendo unos años. Es un lugar al que desde que era chamaquito—antes de todo esto—siempre soñé con ir. Siempre soñé con ir algún día a Los Ángeles porque era fanático de los Lakers y Kobe.

¿Tiene familia en los Estados Unidos? ¿Recuerdas la primera vez que viniste a los Estados Unidos?

Coño. Si no tuviera familia en los Estados Unidos, no sería latino.

Recuerdo la primera vez que vine a los Estados Unidos. Tenía 12 años. Era verano y fui a Connecticut, Rhode Island, Pensilvania. Estuve en casas de diferentes familiares, pero visité Nueva York solo un día, fuimos y volvimos. Lo recuerdo muy bien. Esa fue la primera vez. Y fue la primera y única vez, hasta que crecí.

Read the Cover Story: *Bad Bunny's Next Move*

¿Dónde están las mejores playas? ¿Los Ángeles o Puerto Rico?

[Risas audibles] Ya sabes la respuesta a eso. Puerto Rico, definitivamente 1000 veces. Todavía no me he metido en el agua. Voy a ver si en verano el agua se calienta y luego voy.

Al crecer en el pueblo de Almirante Sur, ¿cuáles fueron sus mejores recuerdos de su infancia?

Siempre digo que tuve una vida muy normal. Crecí con mi mamá y mi papá. Soy el hermano mayor de tres, así que recuerdo haber esperado a mis hermanos. Cuando vino mi primer hermano, Bernie y el segundo, Misael. Mi madre era maestra y mi padre era camionero. Así que sabes que éramos gente trabajadora. Muy católico, nosotros fuimos a la iglesia. Teníamos que hacerlo bien en la escuela. Crecí con mucho amor de mi madre y mi padre. Los vi a veces esforzándose, pasando por momentos difíciles para traernos comida y otros momentos fáciles. Fueron momentos hermosos, a veces de incertidumbre, pero al final siempre agradecido con el núcleo en el que crecí; mi familia, mi barrio, mi pueblo y la forma en que crecí, porque de ahí, adquirí mucha experiencia y muchos conocimientos que me hacen ser la persona que soy hoy.

[video id=nG0HmsuO autostart="viewable"]

¿Qué papel jugó la música en tu vida en tus primeros años?

Lo que más he hecho en la vida es escuchar música. Desde pequeño siempre fui fanático de la música. Yo de niño tenía muchos CDs de salsa, merengue. Mi mamá escuchaba mucho merengue y balada, y mi papá escuchaba salsa. Cuando era ‘chamaquito’ o niño, escuchaba rap y reggaeton. Siempre recuerdo cuando tenía 5 años, para Navidad me regalaron un CD de Vico-C, “Aquel Que Había Muerto,” con la carátula oscura, casi negra, apenas se veía la cara de Vico C. Mi mamá compraba discos de un catálogo, que era como un libro y tú elegías los discos y venían por docenas, bueno, ella elegía como ocho y me dejaba elegir los últimos cuatro. Tomaría CDs de Marc Anthony, Victor Manuel y CDs de música de bolero. Crecí siempre escuchando música y

trataba de imitar las voces de los cantantes y los sonidos que hacían. Desde pequeño siempre fue mi pasión. Siempre fui un gran fan de los artistas. Por eso cuando me preguntan '¿Qué artista te inspiró?' Nunca digo uno solo porque escuché tantos artistas y géneros como el reggaetón, que tiene muchos artistas que me inspiraron, y la salsa. Diría que todo el movimiento de la música latina me inspiró.

¿Qué piensan tus padres y tu familia acerca de que eres el artista más grande del mundo?

No creo que lo sepan. *[Risas]* En realidad, mi papá está orgulloso de mí y está feliz de que me siento bien y de que estoy viviendo mis sueños. Siempre agradezco a Dios que yo, mis amigos y mi familia, mantengamos los pies en la tierra. Voy a la casa de mi papá y me siento tan relajado. Muy normal. Como si no pasara nada. Fuera de esa casa quizás el mundo esté escuchando y hablando de mí, pero en esa casa todo es igual. Nada ha cambiado. Mi papá no actúa de una manera nueva ni me trata de una manera nueva. Para mí es hermoso que me guste ir allí y todavía me miran con ojos de 'Ven aquí, Benito Antonio. El bebé. Su hijo.' ¿Tú entiendes? Mi mamá es igual que mi papá. Por eso digo que no saben pero no en el sentido de que no lo entiendan, es en el sentido de que sigo siendo la misma persona y nada ha cambiado en cómo nos sentimos y nos tratamos. Cada vez que voy a la casa me siento así…un hogar.

Read More: *The 10 Best Albums of 2022*

¿Podrías haberte imaginado dónde estás ahora?

Quizás al principio no hubiera imaginado esto que soñé con esto. Cuando estaba solo en mi habitación haciendo ritmos, soñando que algún día tendría éxito en la música, no. Pero ahora, con el paso del

tiempo y he visto grandes cosas, ahora puedo imaginar lo siguiente y lo siguiente. Recuerdo que hace dos años me decía ‘papi’ ya estoy en un nivel que si bajo no voy a ser el mismo de antes, no voy a poder recuperar mi vida normal por así decirlo. Pero sí, me lo he imaginado, pero si me preguntas desde el principio cuando era chamaquito, no. Cuando era pequeño, solo soñaba con la música y que alguien escuchara mi música, siempre digo eso. Si me escucharan mil personas y yo actuara una vez al mes en un lugarcito, solo con eso sería feliz. Pero el hambre y la pasión que tengo por esto es imposible porque siempre quiero dar más y más y más.

¿Sientes que la aparición de Internet y las plataformas de transmisión como Spotify son razones importantes por las que estás aquí hoy?

Obvio que sí, y sobre esto te puedo decir, por encima de otras personas, que si no fuera por las redes sociales no estaría aquí. Lo que no creo es que sea una ventaja. Hay un montón de artistas del pasado que dicen, ‘Durante mi tiempo no había Spotify. Durante mi tiempo no había Instagram.’ Pero había otras cosas. Por ejemplo, fue más difícil obtener exposición para llegar a la posición. Pero al mismo tiempo fue mejor para aquellos que lo lograron. Ahora estamos en un momento en el que en cualquier momento puedes lanzar una canción. Ahora compito con un millón de personas. Cuando salgo con algo ese mismo día salen mil artistas con canciones. Veinte álbumes saliendo en la misma noche. Antes no, salían uno, dos o tres discos. No había tanta saturación en la música. Sacó un disco ahora y pasa una semana y han llegado 15 discos nuevos. Entonces es más fácil que más personas dejen de escuchar mi álbum y comiencen a escuchar otro. Antes, si comprabas un álbum a $15, no tendrías dinero para comprar otro álbum. Te lo ibas a quemar y ‘pela, pela, pela.’ Hoy no, escuchas mi disco y te aburres, puedes escuchar otros. Así que mantenerte

ahí en la posición de que te sigan escuchando, mantenerte en la posición de que tu álbum siga ‘top,’ es mucho más difícil que antes. Hoy en día es mucho más difícil. Antes escuchabas la misma canción un año entera en la emisora. Es la emisora que pone tu canción y si no les gusta, sí tienes *chavos* (dinero) para pagar la emisora, sino no podrías competir con nadie. Ahora cualquiera pone una canción en los medios y puede ‘pegarla.’

¿Piensas en la competencia de la industria cuando estás en la etapa de creación de tus proyectos?

No. Cuando estoy en el estudio disfruto lo que hago. No estoy pensando en la cantidad de gente que está grabando o no. Yo hago música como si fuera la única persona en el mundo.

¿Te importa mantenerte en tu posición como el artista número uno del mundo?

Siempre digo que no, pero creo que miento, porque al final del día soy muy competitivo, pero con todo. Si estoy jugando al ajedrez, quiero ganar. Si estoy haciendo chistes, quiero contar mejores chistes. Soy muy competitivo. En todas las situaciones. Así que obviamente en la música lo soy. Pero en el buen sentido. Pero no me gusta ver a otros perder. Me gusta que todos ganen. Hay espacio para todos nosotros. Me gusta ver a los demás triunfar y tener éxito. Me gusta ver que la gente tenga buena música porque me hará sentir mejor. Si veo a alguien haciendo una canción que está rompiendo, si hay una canción cabrona, yo voy hacer una canción más cabrona. Quiero hacer algo mejor. Pero no para opacarlo a él, sino porque quiero hacer algo mejor. Podemos brillar todos en el mundo.

Fuiste el artista con más reproducciones en Spotify durante tres años seguidos. ¿Por qué crees que tu música tiene este efecto en la gente?

No sé. La forma en que hago música es de una manera tan real. Le doy tanto amor a la música. Siempre digo que mi mamá me dio tanto amor desde 'chiquito,' por eso tengo tanto que dar al mundo y a los demás. Creo que mis canciones son las mismas. Le doy tanto amor a mis canciones que no se acaba. Esa energía cada vez que escuches mi canción te dará mucha alegría. No hago canciones solo por tirarlas. Cuando tenga una canción para tirar, entonces se tira.

¿Tienes una canción en este momento?

¿Ahora mismo? Sí. *[Alcanza el teléfono en el bolsillo derecho]* Pero no te lo voy a enseñar. *[Risas]*

Read More: *'I Make Music Like I'm the Only Person in the World.' Bad Bunny on Coachella, Hollywood, and Topping Himself*

¿Para quién dirías que haces música? ¿Para Puerto Rico?

Hago música para la gente que me quiere. Cuando leo comentarios que dicen: 'Bad Bunny, ahora no voy a escuchar tu música', está bien. Si ya no quieres escuchar mi música, está bien. Eso está bien, a alguien le gustará. Hago música para quien quiera escucharme y para quien quiera conectar conmigo. Si no te gusta lo que estoy haciendo, no voy a hacer otra cosa para que a ti te guste. Si no te gusta, pues 'brother,' hay muchos artistas por ahí, y tal vez encuentres a alguien que te guste. A alguien le va a gustar lo que estoy haciendo y esas son las personas a las que les estoy cantando. Pero obviamente, sí hago música para Puerto Rico. Es donde nací y

crecí. Soy fan de nuestra gente, de nuestra cultura, de nuestra cultura también dentro del reggaetón. Cuando escribo y hago música mi espíritu siempre está en Puerto Rico y trato de que la música que hago sea del agrado de la gente de allá.

Tu último álbum, Un Verano Sin Ti, fue una experiencia auditiva inmersiva. ¿Por qué era importante para ti traer la experiencia de un verano puertorriqueño al mundo?

Muchos artistas hacen canciones, se tiran una foto, la portada y ya, luego el video y ya está. Quiero crear todo un mundo, un ambiente y un sentimiento entero alrededor de un álbum, desde los videos, las visuales, la portada, la temática, todo sincronizado, con el propósito de que lo escuches para con el propósito de que lo escuches para que te puedas sentir en algún lugar o sentir de alguna manera. Si alguien está en la f-king Suiza, puede sentir que está en el Caribe, puede sentir que está en la playa. Es por eso que todas las imágenes de las canciones son mías en la playa y son 360, así que si te pones los [auriculares de realidad virtual], estarás en la playa conmigo. Si estás en Puerto Rico, aún mejor porque entonces no necesitas los [VR]: estás allí.

Tu productor Tainy es una leyenda en el espacio del reggaetón. ¿Cómo ha sido trabajar con él en tus proyectos?

He sido fan suyo desde siempre. He tenido sueños desde que era chamaquito para trabajar un día con Tainy. Incluso después de que entró en la música, me tomó tiempo poder trabajar con él. Recuerdo cuando hice mi primer disco y me preguntaron, ‘¿Con quién quieres trabajar?’ Y dije: ‘Quiero trabajar con Tainy’. Y hasta

el sol de hoy seguimos trabajando. No trabajo con muchos productores así de mano a mano.

Read More: The Best Latin Songs and Albums of 2022

Tenemos una pregunta en video directamente de Tainy que nos gustaría mostrarle desde nuestro teléfono. *Tainy: Como fan me gustaría saber: ¿Cómo encontraste una manera de poner tanto de ti como Benito la persona, no sólo Bad Bunny el artista en tu música urbana?*

Siempre trato de dar lo más real de mi en mis canciones. Yo soy un chamaquito. *[Risas]* Y tenemos distintas preocupaciones y deseos de hacer una cosa un día y al día siguiente no. Hoy a lo mejor quiero ir a la discoteca a beber y fumar, y mañana quiero estar tranquilo en mi casa viendo una película. El martes quiero hacer ejercicio y el miércoles quiero comer una hamburguesa. Y luego estaré pensando en mi ex o en una chica que me gusta. Y luego mañana estoy molesto por algo que creo que es una injusticia, pero ya por la noche voy a comer tacos, me doy un poco de tequila y se me olvida.

Creo que no hay nada de malo con eso. Por eso mis canciones tienen de todo. Estamos en la discoteca, estamos en la playa, llorando por un amor, estamos molestos por la injusticia social porque así es.

Tu primer proyecto con Tainy fue *Estamos Bien*, el cual dedicaste a las víctimas del huracán María. En ese sentido, la canción habla de la resiliencia de los puertorriqueños. ¿Es importante para usted

hablar sobre las injusticias de Puerto Rico, al mismo tiempo que destaca la resistencia de los Boricuas?

Sí, siempre hay diferentes sentimientos en las canciones para que puedas escucharlo y tomar de él lo que quieras. Por ejemplo, recuerdo cuando estábamos haciendo *Estamos Bien*, también dio una idea de lo que está pasando y lo hice para que también pudieras sentir por la Isla y Puerto Rico. En esa canción también hablo de culos y *chavos* (dinero) y cosas así, más trap para que la gente de la calle que también le gusta eso también y puedan sentir. Para mí podría significar una cosa, pero para otra persona significa otra cosa. Así que siempre trato de hacer eso en las canciones. Si les estoy dando un mensaje, lo haré de una manera que pueda interpretarse en diferentes maneras para que diferentes personas se puedan identificar.

¿Cómo es el reggaetón un género que ofrece la oportunidad no solo de hacer música al estilo perreo *(pistas de fiestas bailables de reggaetón)*, sino también abordar temas sociales y políticos?

¡Sí, sin duda! Creo que el reggaetón y todos los géneros musicales son un medio para expresarse. Siempre lo han sido. La música siempre ha contado historias de cosas buenas, cosas malas, cosas peligrosas, cosas que te molestan. Así que el reggaeton es solo otro género de música que nace de la calle, del barrio. Siempre hay espacio y oportunidad para hablar un poco de todo en los discos de reggaeton. Por eso tengo canciones para la discoteca. Tengo música para todo.

¿Crees que los elementos de raza y color están involucrados en determinar quién tiene éxito en el

espacio del reggaetón?

Me han preguntado eso antes…ha pasado mucho tiempo desde que tuve una pregunta como esa. Dentro de mi ignorancia no lo entendía. Dije que eso no puede ser. No podía imaginarlo. No puedo decir que sí o que no porque no lo he vivido.Tampoco he visto con mis propios ojos que sí, esta persona no se volvió más exitosa debido a su piel, no lo he visto. Sería irresponsable de mi parte decir que sí. Por ejemplo, me preguntaron si Tego Calderón, si hubiera sido más grande si no fuera negro. Pero a mis ojos, Tego Calderón es el cantante más grande de la industria. ¿Tú entiendes? No entendía cosas sobre la industria que tal vez sean ciertas. Quizás las puertas se cerraron por su piel, quizás algún promotor prefirió a un artista más blanco que él. Pero esas cosas no las sé, no las he vivido. Cuando me preguntaron dije: '¿Qué? Para mí Tego Calderón es el cantante más grande del género, también es uno de mis ídolos. ¿Qué quieres decir con no tan grande? ¿Quién es más grande que él?'

¿Es importante para ti dar tus flores a los grandes como Calderón y los que te han inspirado?

Sí, claro. Para mí es importante mantener siempre el respeto por aquellos que lo merecen. Si ves a alguien por quien te sientes inspirado y admirado, dilo y dilo con respeto. No importa lo grande que crezca, incluyo personas que me han inspirado que para mejor no necesariamente estaría aquí, yo no tengo nombre pero hay artistas que yo escuchaba y los veo y los respeto por igual. No quiero olvidarme de su historia.

¿Cuál fue su proceso y enfoque para crear su actuación en los Grammy?

Nunca me dijeron qué hacer. Me dieron la libertad de hacer lo que quisiera y supe que quería cantar “Después De La Playa”. Mucha gente pensó que interpretaría “Titi Me Pregunto” o “Moscow Mule,” pero yo sabía que quería hacer “Después De La Playa.” Pero yo quería algo más. Así que tuve la idea de hacer la primera parte de “El Apagón,” y mano, la idea surgió de forma muy espontánea y natural. En Puerto Rico en el mes de enero se celebra la fiesta de la calle San Sebastián. Es un festival puertorriqueño súper grande y tradicional donde verás personalidades retratadas por los cabezudos. Increíblemente, en toda mi vida nunca he estado en uno. Así que pensé que este año quería ir. Pensé que encontraría la manera de ponerme allí, pero no pude porque estaba aquí, así que pensé, sabes qué, traeré las fiestas de San Sebastián a los Grammy. En realidad no sabía que iba a ser el acto de apertura. Eso fue algo que se decidió en el último minuto. Creo que después de ver el programa pensaron en ponerlo como el primer acto. Y yo dije, ‘¿primero?’ Fue todo muy natural.

Read More: *Allow Bad Bunny to Teach You Puerto Rican Slang*

Durante su actuación, hubo subtítulos que decían “Non-English” en el programa. Sus fanáticos expresaron su decepción en las redes sociales. ¿Cuál fue tu reacción cuando viste eso por primera vez?

En realidad, cuando lo vi… no capté el mensaje. No decía ‘en español’… como que ‘non English’… bueno, el sistema no funciona. Fue una porquería, esa es la única forma en que podría decirlo.

Uno de los temas que elegiste para la interpretación, El Apagón, es uno de tus discos

más directos políticamente. ¿Qué significa para ti la letra ‘Todo quiere ser latino… pero les falta sazón, batería y reggaetón’?

¡Esa línea es de Tego Calderón! Lo que sucede cuando estás creando música, especialmente a mí, es que soy el tipo de persona que cambia de humor rápidamente. Así que cuando escribí esa canción estaba molesto. Pensé: esta gente… ¿qué piensan? Eso por el momento… hay artistas que quieren hacer cosas y también ahora, mencionaron sus raíces latinas que nunca han dicho pero ahora por el momento, sí quieres hacer una canción en español. Cabrona, llevas 20 años cantando y ahora quieres hacer una canción en español? ¿No lo hiciste en tu mejor momento pero ahora quieres hacer una canción en español porque no estás apagá en tu mejor momento? Entonces cosas así las veo y en ese momento me molestó. Pero ahora ese sentimiento me ha superado. No es que me sienta así en este momento. Es bueno hacer lo que quieras. Y lo mismo para otros artistas que son gringos que nunca tendrían la oportunidad de trabajar con un artista latino o hacer una canción en español, y ahora los ves mirando la música latina porque está en la cima. Se volvió ‘cool’ ser latino. No solo están haciendo la música, están tratando de copiar el flujo de los latinos. Pero luego pienso; nuestra cultura y nuestra música se extienden por todas partes. Impacta a personas en otros lugares. Quieren probarlo y sentirlo. Entonces, ¿por qué me va a molestar eso, sí lo hacen con respeto?

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La Ley 60 es una ley que invita a los extranjeros a mudarse a Puerto Rico por sus beneficios contributivos. ¿Cómo se siente acerca de los no

puertorriqueños que vienen a la isla y contribuyen a la gentrificación y el desplazamiento de los nativos?

Me molesta mucho. Creo que lo que más me molesta es que quieran venir, tomar posesión, ocupar un espacio, pero no quieren abrazar nada, ni ayudar. No quieren devolver. Cuando vas a un barrio nuevo siempre te van a mirar raro porque eres del otro lado. Van a sentir que les estás quitando algo, como cuando te ven usando la cancha de baloncesto y no eres de ahí, claro que te mirarán mal. Pero si esa persona abraza y aporta al barrio estoy seguro que de alguna manera te aceptará poco a poco. Esto es bueno. ¿Tú entiendes? Creo que eso es todo. El otro día estaba viendo un TikTok de una chica blanca hablando del huracán María con tanta alegría, diciendo que fue lo mejor que le pasó a Puerto Rico. Lo dijo muy contenta, y claro, sí los puertorriqueños buscamos lo positivo de las situaciones por encima de lo negativo. Pero no es lo mismo. Entonces creo que eso es lo que más me molesta, no tener empatía ni respeto por el lugar del que se van a beneficiar.

¿Cómo es para ti ser un artista tan importante en los Estados Unidos cuando hay tensiones tan fuertes entre los dos? ¿Alguna vez has sentido que tienes la obligación de educar?

Sí, siempre se lo hablo a mis amigos de aquí. Si estoy con alguien a quien puedo educar, lo haré. Siempre lo hago. Y no solo en las canciones o la entrevista. Lo hago en la vida real. Si estoy con alguien y escuchó algo muy ignorante sobre mi país o mi cultura, siempre trato de educarlo, como ‘No, no es así.’

¿Cree que el gobierno de Estados Unidos le ha fallado al pueblo puertorriqueño?

[Ríe inmediatamente] Yo creo que el gobierno le ha fallado a Puerto Rico, le ha fallado a Estados Unidos. Igualmente, Puerto Rico le ha fallado a Puerto Rico. Creo que todos los gobiernos le han fallado a su país alguna vez.

¿Sientes que es injusto que te lleguen estas cuestiones políticas que tienes que hablar en nombre de toda la Isla?

Sí, creo que es injusto. Y es por eso que algunos artistas no lo hacen. Si no hablas de eso en tus canciones, no recibirás este tipo de preguntas. No le van a preguntar a Daddy Yankee, no le van a preguntar algo así. No sé por qué dije Daddy Yankee, lo siento Daddy Yankee. No les preguntarán algo así porque no habla de eso en las canciones. Limitaré hablar de eso porque entonces no quiero que me pregunten. Cuando estoy escribiendo mi música no estoy pensando, 'Bueno, entonces me van a preguntar'. Estoy pensando simplemente en expresarme en ese momento. Porque cuando me preguntan puede ser difícil para mí responder porque no soy tan bueno con mis palabras cuando hablo. Pero en las canciones sí, ahí lo diré porque ahí es donde me siento cómodo, me siento inteligente, me siento capaz. En mis canciones podré expresarme plenamente como quiero la pregunta podría ser un poco injusta porque simplemente hago una canción y luego una responsabilidad tan grande cae sobre mi. Esa responsabilidad no es solo mía. Si no sacará esa canción hablando de algo nadie me preguntaría. No estaríamos haciendo una entrevista con ese tipo de pregunta.

Sigues el mantra "yo hago lo que me da la gana" como se menciona en el título de tu segundo

álbum YHLQMDLG. Cuanto más famoso te vuelves, ¿sigues pensando que sigue siendo así?

Sí. Porque no me importa la fama. No me importa esa presión de la que hablábamos. No me importa eso. Soy una persona. Soy un ser humano y cometo errores. Siempre he dicho que voy a vivir como quiera. Pero yo nunca me limito de hacer de una manera o actuar de una manera por lo que van a decir o pensar, no. Soy famoso y no dejó de ser humano.

Tu aparición en Bullet Train junto a Brad Pitt fue épica. ¿De dónde viene tu interés por la actuación y cómo fue esa experiencia?

Siempre me ha gustado actuar. Donde crecí, si algo te gusta es lo único que te gusta. Es complicado tomar clases de música, piano, canto y actuación. Requiere dinero y tiempo. Cuando creces donde las condiciones no son las de la ciudad como San Juan, tienes casi todo, teatros y esas cosas. Siempre me gustó actuar, pero no más que la música. La música siempre primero. Entonces, cuando llegó la oportunidad de actuar, llegó gracias a mi fama y éxito en la música. Lo he probado y me gusta. La experiencia del Bullet Train fue súper cabrón.

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¿Qué fue más difícil? ¿Pelea con Brad Pitt o pelea con Mizz en WWE?

Definitivamente peleando con Brad Pitt. Esa pelea fue dura porque fue física y seria. Pero los dos eran *cabronas* (peleas increíbles). El día con Mizz, esa pelea ese día fue el mejor día de mi vida.

¿Sientes que cuanto más famoso te vuelves, más fans invaden tu espacio personal?

Creo que es posible que operen de otra manera. Si entendieran que somos iguales, somos humanos, que no debemos ser agresivos, ¿por qué invadir mi espacio privado? Siempre lo he dicho, que nunca le voy a negar un saludo a alguien. Nunca te voy a dejar con la mano extendida para saludarme, jamás. Si te acercas a mí como si fueras a robar, entonces sí, me voy a molestar. Alguien me pide una foto, estiro la mano y ahí la dejan porque están buscando el teléfono. ¿Por qué quieres una foto contigo? ¿Por qué soy la estatua de la libertad? Soy un humano, saludame. La foto no vale más que un saludo. Una foto no vale más que un intercambio de palabras. Eso vale más que una foto. Puedes decir que yo conocí a Bad Bunny. ¿Prefieres conocerme o hacerte una foto conmigo?

¿Todavía vives en Puerto Rico?

Siempre digo que vivo en PR porque, no sé. Podría estar dos años en L.A. pero siempre diré que vivo en Puerto Rico. Ahora estoy aquí en Los Ángeles por un ratito. Me gustaría mudarme a otros lugares, a Nueva York. Pero sí, mi casa es Puerto Rico. Digo que todavía vivo en Puerto Rico porque sé que es un ratito. Solo por un rato buscando otras experiencias. Pero al final del día siempre regresaré a Puerto Rico y me quedaré para siempre.

Su película Cassandro recibió revuelo en el Festival de Cine de Sundance. ¿Cómo fue esa experiencia?

Asombroso, esa fue una de mis primeras experiencias actuando. Recuerdo que estaba nervioso. Creo que estaba más nervioso que con Bullet Train porque era mi primera experiencia. No quería

‘joderlo’ o dañarlo. Actuar con Gael fue genial y me trataron súper bien. Me alegro que haya sido mi primera experiencia.

Tu primer beso en pantalla fue con Gael García Bernal. ¿Cómo fue eso?

Está cabrón. Mi primer beso para una película, y fue con un hombre. Ese es el castigo que recibo por estar con tantas mujeres durante mi vida. *[Comienza a reír]* Si estás actuando, estás siendo alguien que no eres. Esa es la parte divertida. Entonces, cuando me preguntaron por eso, dije: ‘Sí, estoy aquí para lo que quieras’. No me sentí incómodo. Es parte de la actuación. Es parte de lo que estoy haciendo.

¿Algo que puedas compartir sobre tu película de Marvel ‘El Muerto’?

Aún no hemos grabado ninguna escena. Quizá me cambien por Pedro Pascal. *[Risas]*

Siempre has sido fanático de la lucha libre. ¿Cómo fue ese día al subir al ring de la WWE?

El mejor día de mi vida. Nunca antes había sentido ese tipo de adrenalina. Yo quería explotar. Era como si volviera a ser un niño, y en la pelea, fue un abrir y cerrar de ojos. Todo sucedió rápido.

Read More: *How Puerto Ricans Are Fighting Back Against the Outsiders Using the Island as a Tax Haven*

Parece que has estado aprendiendo mucho inglés. ¿Aprender el idioma es algo por lo que te sentiste presionado o que siempre te interesó?

No. Siempre he dicho que debo aprender. Hay muchas cosas que estoy perdiendo, como oportunidades, por el idioma. No me importaba [aprender] inglés. Pero ahora si, creo que me importa. Ha sido tan natural simplemente hablar y practicar, pero sin presión o con un objetivo o algo así.

¿Te molesta que la gente te pregunte si alguna vez harás música en inglés?

No, porque creo que es una pregunta justa. Pero nadie le pregunta a Drake cuándo va a hacer una canción en español. El día que sienta que necesito hacer una canción en inglés, lo haré porque lo siento.

¿Dijiste que 2023 es el año para ti?

Todos los días hago ejercicio, descanso, veo televisión, escribo música, pero sin presión, no es que tenga que hacerlo, es porque me gusta.

Tainy nos dijo que te gusta decorar tus estudios de acuerdo a tu ambiente. ¿Cómo está decorado tu estudio actualmente?

Para *Un Verano Sin Ti*, puse plantitas para que pareciera tropical. Ahora he creado un espacio que parece de los años 70, muy colorido, vintage. Colores de esa época. Estoy en esa vibra ahora mismo. Estoy comprando autos de los 70, mierda de los 70. Drogas de los 70. *[Risas]*

Eres el primer latino en encabezar el famoso festival de música de Coachella en Indio, California. ¿Cómo te sientes al entrar?

Mucha gente me pregunta eso en la calle. Estoy como, ‘¿Se supone que debo sentir algo?’ Me presenté en Azteca, me presenté en el Yankee Stadium. He hecho función en todos los lugares. Coachella va a ser otra f-king función para mí. Sentí más presión en el Hiram Bithorn [Estadio en Puerto Rico] que en Coachella. Obviamente estoy emocionado. Quiero dar lo mejor de mí.

Tu show en el Yankee Stadium fué icónico. ¿Quieres que Coachella lo supere?

Hay muchas megaestrellas que se han presentado en Coachella antes, así que no quiero competir con ninguna de ellas. Solo quiero ser yo mismo. Muchas leyendas han actuado en Coachella pero nadie como yo. Nunca ha habido un Benito actuando en Coachella. Y eso es lo bueno para mí.

¿Qué quieres que experimenten tus fans en tu set de Coachella?

Quiero que disfruten del ‘show.’ Quiero que la gente se sienta libre como, ‘esto es Coachella, pero no es Coachella,’ estamos en el barrio, en la playa. En Coachella, nunca ha habido alguien de donde vengo. No ha ido nadie con lo que voy a llevar. Quiero que la gente no sienta presión ni responsabilidad. Vamos a disfrutar donde estamos ahora porque no sabemos a dónde vamos a estar después.

Estuve mirando todos los folletos de Coachella desde el ‘99. Olvidé que lo estaba haciendo este año. Vi que decía mi nombre para 2023, pensé que era falso. Fue un poco impresionante. Todas las personas que han estado y ahora soy yo, pero eso no cambia quién soy como artista y como persona. Si estoy ahí es porque hago bien mi trabajo. No quiero intentar hacer algo más grande que Beyonce o Radiohead.

Por último, necesitamos saber… ¿Tienes una canción con Justin Bieber a punto de salir?

¿Hay una canción con Justin Bieber? ¿Es un rumor? No, no tengo una canción con Justin Bieber. Eso es falso. Nunca vas a saber lo que voy a hacer. No te mientas a ti mismo, no vas a saber mi próxima movida.

—*Reportando en Español por Israel Meléndez Ayala*

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